

The Retired Dragon Slayer Teaches Pottery

THE RETIRED DRAGON SLAYER TEACHES POTTERY

A Retired-Adventurer Cozy Fantasy Novel

The Thistlewick Chronicles, Book 1

William M. Soileau

Prologue

Twenty-six years before a dragon knocked on a potter's door, Branwen Ashcombe stood in the ruin of Ashgrove with a spear still warm in her hands and learned, for the first time, that a contract could be correct on paper and still be wrong in every way that mattered.

The village had burned two nights before her arrival. By the time her unit reached it, the fire was long out and the grieving had already hardened into the particular numb efficiency of people who had buried what they could and were now simply waiting for someone official to tell them what came next. Branwen had been sent to hunt the creature responsible — gold-green, wing-scarred, last seen crossing the eastern ridge at dawn — and she had tracked it for six days through country that grew wilder and colder with every mile, until she found not the beast the villagers described but its den, three days after the beast itself had already fled south, empty but for the wreckage of something that had clearly, recently, held young.

She had not known, then, standing in that cold den with her spear lowered and her breath fogging in the mountain air, that the raid which had provoked Ashgrove's burning had been the Guild's own — an unconfirmed sweep of the ridge, authorized on thin evidence, that had found and destroyed a nest weeks before anyone thought to ask what, exactly, the sweep had been searching for in the first place. She learned that later, much later, buried in a filing room in the capital on a rain-soaked afternoon when she'd gone looking for an entirely different record and found this one instead, and by then the Ashgrove contract had already been folded into the Guild's standing orders, unclosed, waiting for a confirmed sighting that might never come.

She told no one. There was no one left, she told herself, who would benefit from the knowledge — the villagers had their grief and their rebuilt roofs, the Guild had its tally, and the creature itself, wherever it had fled, was beyond anything her confession could repair. She carried the knowledge instead the way she carried every other hard fact her thirty-one years in the Guild had handed her: quietly, privately, filed away in the same place she kept the faces she could no longer remember and the wingbeats she could never forget.

It was not until a cave near Millbrook, years later, holding a dead dragon's half-finished clay cup in her own two scarred hands, that she

understood what that quiet filing had actually cost her — not absolution, which she had never truly expected, but the simple, ordinary chance to have done something, anything, with the truth besides bury it alongside everything else she'd rather not examine too closely.

She did not know, standing in that cave, that the truth she'd buried at Ashgrove would one day walk through her own studio doorway, old and scarred and impossibly patient, asking not for justice, and not for revenge, but for something so much smaller and so much harder to refuse: a single lesson, freely given, from the one person in the whole wide kingdom who had once had every reason to end him and had chosen, instead, four years before he ever arrived, to learn how to build something with her hands instead.

That choice, made alone in a converted sheep barn on a quiet autumn morning, was the whole of what made the doorway, when it finally darkened, survivable for them both.

This is the story of what came after.

Chapter 1: Clay and Quiet

The wheel had a wobble in it that Branwen Ashcombe had never bothered to fix, because the wobble taught patience faster than a perfect wheel ever could. She kicked it into a slow, even spin and watched the cone of clay rise between her palms, gray and cool and slick with the morning's first water, and thought, not for the first time, that this was the best trick she had ever learned. Better than the low guard. Better than the underhand feint that had ended six different fights before they started. You put your hands where you wanted the world to go, and — mostly, if you were patient, if you didn't fight it — it went there.

"You're doing the thing with your jaw again," said Tam Whistler, age eleven, who was supposed to be centering his own lump of clay and was instead watching hers with the frank, unblinking attention children reserve for things they intend to steal later, or grow up to be.

"What thing."

"The thing where you look like you're about to hit something."

Branwen eased off the pedal. The cone slumped obligingly back into a dome, wet and patient, waiting for her to decide what came next. "That's my centering face. Everyone gets one, eventually. Yours is going to be worse than mine."

"Da doesn't get one when he's kneading bread."

"Your da's dough has never once tried to fly off the wheel and hit him in the teeth." She nodded at Tam's own lump, gray and lopsided and going nowhere fast, wobbling on its bat like a drunk trying to stand. "Wet your hands again. You're fighting it. Clay knows when you're fighting it — it goes stiff on you out of spite."

Beside Tam, his sister Ivy — nine, and considerably more patient, or considerably more stubborn, Branwen still hadn't decided which — had abandoned centering three minutes ago in favor of building a small, determined pinch pot with the single-minded focus of a mason laying a cornerstone. It listed badly to the left, one wall thumbed thin enough to show daylight through it, the rim uneven as a row of crooked teeth. She turned it in her small clay-crusted hands like it was the finest thing anyone

had ever made, which, this being the first thing she had ever made, in her own accounting, it was.

Morning light came low and gold through the barn's east window, the good window, the one Branwen had widened herself with a crowbar and four ruined fingernails the first autumn she'd owned the place, back when the whole barn had still smelled of sheep and rot and someone else's failed ambitions. Dust turned lazy in the light now, catching and drifting and catching again, and the smell of wet clay and cold ash and the faint green sweetness of drying willow bats sat over the whole room like something solid enough to lean against. Outside, Thistlewick was waking up the way it always woke up: slow, damp, smelling of turned earth and woodsmoke and, underneath it all, the warm yeasted breath of Cormac Pell's ovens two streets over, carried on whatever wind happened to be blowing that morning. A rooster somewhere insisted, with more confidence than evidence, that the sun needed his help to rise. A dog barked twice at nothing and gave it up. Somewhere down the lane a cart wheel found every loose cobble on its way to market.

Branwen liked mornings here in a way she had never once liked a morning on campaign, where waking meant checking your boots for anything that had crawled in overnight and running a thumb along your spear's edge before you'd even had water, because rust didn't wait for you to feel ready. Here, waking meant this: cold clay under her nails before breakfast, two children arguing gently over whose pot would survive the kiln, and a window she'd built with her own hands letting in exactly the kind of light that made the whole ordinary business of the morning feel, every single day, like something she had genuinely earned rather than merely been allowed.

She had been a slayer for thirty-one years. She had been a potter for four. Some days the four still felt like the newer, stranger fact, the one that needed explaining, even though nobody in Thistlewick had asked her to explain it in longer than she could remember. That was the gift of the place, she'd decided early on and had never once had cause to reconsider: nobody here had ever seen her fight. They only knew her hands from this — steadying a child's wrist against the wheel's pull, wedging the air bubbles out of a lump of river clay with the heel of one palm, the small domestic violence of wire-cutting a finished bowl free of its bat, that clean singing

snap of taut wire through wet clay that she still, four years on, found more satisfying than she was strictly willing to admit out loud.

"Miss Branwen." Ivy held up her pot, both hands cupped beneath it like an offering. "Is it good?"

"It's yours," Branwen said, which was the answer she gave to that question every single time, because it was always true and it always satisfied them, and because the alternative — telling a nine-year-old that her first pot listed like a ship going down in a storm, that its walls were thin as a coin on one side and thick as a thumb on the other — served nobody at all. "Put it on the rack, gently, thumbs under the base. Mind the door on your way, it sticks."

The door of the studio didn't creak. She'd oiled the hinges herself in her second month here, unable to stand a door that announced itself before she could see who was coming through it — an old habit, one of the ones that had outlived its use years ago and refused, stubbornly, to die anyway, the way certain habits do, curling up somewhere at the base of you and waiting. So the first she knew of anything, that morning, was the light changing.

Not dimming, exactly. Bending. As if something very large had come to stand just outside the doorway, close enough that its shadow ought to have fallen long and dark across the floorboards, and hadn't, because whatever it was, was being careful.

Tam and Ivy didn't notice. Children rarely notice the moment before something happens; they're too busy, always, in the moment they're already in — Ivy still turning her lopsided pot in the light, Tam still glaring resentfully at his own uncooperative lump of clay as though it had personally insulted him. Branwen noticed. Thirty-one years had built a second spine into her, one that ran quieter and faster than the first, humming along beneath the ordinary business of an ordinary Tuesday morning, and it was that second spine that turned her toward the doorway a full two seconds before anything in the doorway actually moved.

Nothing was there. And then something was, filling the frame the way a held breath fills a chest, gold-green and enormous and so utterly still that it took her mind a long, strange moment to file it as alive rather than as some elaborate stone carving somebody had rolled up to her door as a joke gone too far.

A dragon.

Not the shape from the broadsheets, the rearing silhouette with wings flung wide enough to eclipse a whole castle wall, breath a plume of orange annihilation — this one was crouched low and small as it could physically make itself, which was still the size of a cart-horse and a half, folded in on itself with the particular hunched, apologetic posture of something enormous trying very hard not to be seen, the way a big man ducks his head walking through a low doorway even when the doorway's already cleared him. Its scales had gone the dull gold-green of an old coin left too long in a drawer, tarnished and soft-looking rather than gleaming. One eye — slit-pupiled, amber, the size of a dinner plate — was fixed on her with an expression she had seen exactly once before in her life, on the face of a man surrendering a sword he'd been ordered to keep fighting with long after his own body had stopped believing in the order.

Branwen's hand was on the spear before she decided to move it.

She kept the spear on the wall above the drying rack, mounted on two iron pegs, more habit than weapon at this point — the way some men keep their old uniform folded in a trunk they never open, telling themselves it's for the wool moths' sake and knowing, somewhere underneath, that it isn't. She had oiled it as recently as last spring. She had told herself, oiling it, that this was purely practical, purely for the wood of the haft, so it wouldn't crack in the cold months. She had not examined that explanation too closely, because some explanations only survive the light if you never once hold them up to it.

Her fingers closed around the haft and the whole room went very quiet, the good quiet of the morning — dust and clay-smell and a rooster somewhere still insisting — replaced all at once by a different, older quiet, the kind that used to settle over a battlefield right before.

"Miss Branwen?" Tam's voice, gone small.

She didn't look at him. She kept her eyes on the dragon, and the dragon kept its eyes on her, and neither of them moved, and the spear stayed exactly where it was in her hand, not yet raised, not yet lowered, balanced exactly between the two the way she herself felt balanced, standing there in the gold morning light, between the woman who had killed forty of these and the woman who had spent four years teaching children to make bowls.

The dragon's throat worked, a visible ripple beneath the scales, once, twice. A sound came out of it, low and rasping, clearly unpracticed, like a voice that hadn't spoken this language — or perhaps any language at all — in a very long time, the words emerging thick and effortful, the way a man speaks after a fever finally breaks.

"Please," it said. "I am not — I have not come to — "

It stopped. The throat worked again, and this time the word came out steadier, though no less strange in that enormous, ancient chest.

"I would like a lesson."



Branwen had faced down worse things without her heart doing what it did now, which was nothing at all — not racing, not slowing, just stopped, the way a wheel stops when you take your foot off the pedal and let the clay settle wherever its own momentum happens to leave it.

"Children," she said, without turning around, in the voice she used for *put the tools down, we're done for today,* level and unhurried on the surface, "go home. Tell your mother I said the lesson ran long and there's no charge."

"Is that a—" Ivy started, craning around Branwen's hip for a better look.

"Home. Now. Straight down the lane, don't look back, don't run." She had learned, in thirty-one years, exactly how much true urgency to load into a voice so a child would obey without being frightened badly enough to trip over their own feet on the cobbles. She put that much in now, no more.

They went. She heard the studio door — her door, oiled quiet — swing and settle behind them, heard two sets of small feet break into a trot the instant they judged themselves safely out of earshot, which they were not, quite, and she heard Tam say, breathless, half delighted and half horrified, *that was a dragon, that was an actual dragon* — before the sound of them thinned into the lane's general morning noise and was gone.

Which left Branwen Ashcombe alone in a converted sheep barn with the last dragon in the eastern range, a spear in her hand she had not yet decided whether to raise, and a question hanging in the settled dust

between them that she had genuinely, honestly never once imagined anyone asking her again, not after four years of quiet mornings and gray clay and children's crooked pots drying in a row on the rack.

A lesson.

The dragon had gone very still, the particular stillness of something bracing to be struck and trying, with what dignity it could muster, not to show the bracing. Its wings — she could see now, folded impossibly tight against its flanks, each fold precise as a letter creased for the post — were scarred along both leading edges, old scars, pale and ropy against the dulled gold-green, the exact kind of scarring that came from a slaying contract's standard opening maneuver: hobble the wings first, from a safe range, before you ever close to finish it.

She knew that scar pattern the way she knew the backs of her own hands. She had made scars exactly like it, four decades of them, spread across the kingdom in dragons whose names she had never once learned and whose faces she genuinely, honestly could not remember — not one, not a single one — though she remembered every wingbeat and every hobbling throw and every kill shot with the clean, terrible precision of a woman who had done a thing ten thousand times until her hands stopped needing her mind's permission to do it.

She lowered the spear. Not because she had decided, in that moment, to trust the creature crouched in her doorway. Because she had looked, finally, truly looked, for the first time since it had darkened her threshold, past the size and the scars and the old animal alarm ringing in her blood — and what she had seen wasn't a threat crouched to spring at all. It was something old and frightened, trying, with visible and costly effort, to make itself smaller than it was, the way you learn to do when you've discovered, over a very long life, that your size is the first and sometimes only thing anyone will ever hate you for.

"What's your name," she said. Her voice came out rougher than she meant it to, scraped thin somewhere in her chest.

The dragon blinked, slow, both lids moving in that unsettling reptile sequence, bottom then top, that made her stomach turn over slightly even now. "I have had several. The last was given to me by a man I killed for it, which seemed, in time, a poor way to have come by it in the first place." A pause, the same unpracticed rasp working through the words like an old

hinge slowly finding its motion again after long disuse. "You may call me Fennimore, if a name is required. Fen, if it is not."

"Branwen," she said, though the whole village knew her name, had known it for four years, and she suspected — from the careful, deliberate way its throat had worked before it ever knocked at her door, as though rehearsing — that this dragon had known it too, and had come here on purpose, and not by any accident at all.

"I know," Fen said. Confirmed it, plain as weather. "You are the reason I am the last."

The spear went back onto its pegs. Her hands did it without waiting for her opinion on the matter, the way hands sometimes act on a decision the rest of you is still catching up to.

"Then you'd better come in," Branwen said, "and mind the door. It doesn't creak on purpose, and I intend to keep it that way."



He did not fit through the door. This became apparent almost immediately, in a manner that would have been comic if the morning had held any room left in it for comedy at all — one shoulder wedged hard against the frame, a low pained huff of held breath escaping through his nostrils, a scatter of dry mud sifting down from the lintel where a wingtip caught and dragged along the old wood. Branwen watched him try three different angles, each one worse than the last, before she held up a flat hand.

"Stop. You'll bring the whole frame down and then neither of us has a studio to argue in." She considered him — the sheer wrong-shaped bulk of him, folded and refolded against a doorway built for sheep and farmers, not for this — with the flat, assessing eye she used to judge whether a green student's pot would survive its first trip through the kiln. "There's a hay door. Round the side. Bigger, and it doesn't matter a whit if you scrape the paint, because there isn't any left to scrape."

The hay door was the width of a small barn's mouth, built in some previous owner's more prosperous years for cart-loads of fodder, long before Branwen had gutted the place and rebuilt it around a wheel and a kiln and a life she'd had to invent from nothing. Fen folded himself through it with the particular controlled misery of something enormous trying very

hard to be delicate, wings drawn in so tight they trembled visibly with the effort, and came to rest — crouched, coiled, still trying, even now, to occupy less space than his body strictly permitted him — in the wide central bay where she stored her greenware and stacked her drying boards in their careful, dust-furred rows.

Up close, in full daylight, he was worse and better than he'd looked filling the doorway. Worse, because she could see all of him now: the wing-scars catching the light in pale, ropy lines; a puckered old burn along one flank that looked, on closer study, self-inflicted, the particular scarring pattern of a creature's own fire turning back on it in panic; claws worn strangely blunt at their tips, as if he'd been walking on them, dragging them across rock and dirt, for longer than claws were ever built to bear the wear of. Better, because up close his eyes weren't a predator's eyes at all. They were an old man's eyes, tired in a way that had nothing whatsoever to do with the early hour, the particular tiredness that settles into a body that has simply, for a very long time, kept going.

"You said I was the reason you're the last," Branwen said. She did not sit. She stood near the wheel, close enough to reach the spear pegs again if the morning turned on her, and hated the calculation even as she made it, and made it anyway, because thirty-one years didn't unlearn itself in the space of a single strange dawn. "Say the rest of it."

Fen's throat worked again, the ripple traveling the length of it. "Forty-one of us, in the eastern range, when the Guild first opened its ledgers against my kind. You were sent for eleven of those forty-one. You closed all eleven contracts, cleanly, by the Guild's own account." A pause, longer this time. "I watched four of the eleven happen. From a distance. I was young enough, then, that the distance felt like safety, the way a child believes the blanket pulled to his chin will actually stop something from coming through the dark."

Branwen said nothing. There was nothing in her, just then, to say. She had known the number — forty confirmed kills, the Guild had been proud enough of the tally to carve it into a bronze plaque she'd made them take down, physically, with her own hands, the week before she left — but she had never once, not on the very worst nights, sat with the knowledge that some of those forty had watched each other die and lived on carrying it, the way she now, standing in her own gold-lit barn, was being asked to carry the same weight from the other side of the spear for the very first time.

"The others," she said. "The other thirty."

"Guild contracts I was not named in, and cannot speak to with any confidence. Old age, some. One to a landslide, in the second winter after the war formally ended, which none of your kind killed at all, though I imagine it was counted against your tally regardless, because tallies do not care for shrinking, only for growing." Fen's great head tilted, slow and almost curious, studying her the way she'd studied his scars a moment before. "You look as though that is not the answer you wanted."

"I don't know what answer I wanted," Branwen said, honestly, which was not a sentence she said often, to anyone, and it surprised her enough, hearing it leave her own mouth, that she sat down after all, on the low stool by the wheel, spear-reach be damned. "Why here. Why now. Why a lesson, of all the things in this world you could have come here to ask a slayer for."

The great head lowered, not in submission exactly, but in the particular unguarded way of someone finally, after a very long carry, setting a weight down on solid ground.

"Because I am the last," Fen said again, softer now, the words coming easier the second time, as though the saying of them had worn a groove. "And when I am gone, there will be nothing left in this world that remembers what my hands — such as they are, such as they were ever allowed to be — could have made, if anyone had ever once shown them how to make anything at all besides ash. I have burned villages I regret, and villages I do not, because I was young and frightened and it is what we were bred and trained for, in the war, the same as your spear was what you were trained for. I would like, before there is no one left of my kind to know it ever happened, to make one single thing that is not a memory of fire." His amber eye held hers, unblinking, ancient, and entirely without threat in it. "I am told there is a woman in Thistlewick who teaches anyone patient enough to sit at her wheel. I did not know, when I set out from the eastern range, that she would be the very same woman who ended eleven of my brothers and sisters. I considered turning back, more than once, on the long walk here. I am an old creature, Branwen Ashcombe. I no longer have years enough left to spend turning back from things."

The barn held the silence the way it held woodsmoke — settled into every corner, patient, unhurried, thick enough to taste. Somewhere outside, Cormac's ovens exhaled their morning smell down the lane, and a dog barked twice more and gave it up entirely this time, and the ordinary

machinery of Thistlewick's Tuesday turned over without the faintest idea that a dragon crouched, right now, in its potter's barn, asking, in a voice unused to asking anything at all, to be taught.

Branwen looked down at her own hands. Rough-knuckled, permanently clay-stained now into every crease no matter how she scrubbed them of an evening, a burn scar of her own tracking pale down the left forearm from a fire that had nothing at all to do with dragons and everything to do with a kiln accident her second winter here, before she'd learned to trust the flue and respect what a bad draft could do in half a second of inattention. Hands that had ended eleven creatures like the one folded, miserable and hopeful, into her barn. Hands that had, in the four years since, taught nineteen children and six adults and one deeply stubborn retired blacksmith how to center a lump of clay without fighting it.

She had spent four years telling herself the second set of facts had quietly, gradually replaced the first. She understood now, looking at Fen, that they had only ever sat on top of each other all along, the way a fresh coat of slip sits invisibly over an old crack in greenware — smooth, unremarkable, until the kiln's heat finds the weakness and the whole thing comes apart cleanly along the one seam nobody had thought to check closely enough.

"I'm not going to promise you this ends well," she said finally. "The village will see you before I'm ready for them to, or the Guild will hear a rumor on some trade road and send someone, and I know exactly how that particular visit goes because I used to be the one making it, riding into some quiet village with my spear across my back and everyone's eyes sliding away from mine. I can't promise you any of that turns out kindly. I won't lie to you about the shape of what's ahead, not on your very first morning here."

"I did not come here for a promise," Fen said. "I came here for a lesson."

Something in Branwen's chest — old, armored, a door she had genuinely believed rusted shut these four years past — gave a fraction of an inch, the way a stuck hinge gives before it finally, reluctantly, moves.

"Tomorrow," she heard herself say. "Before sunrise. There's fewer eyes to see you then, and less to explain if someone does." She stood, because

standing was easier, just then, than sitting with the full weight of what she'd just agreed to. "Don't be seen getting here. I mean that plainly. Not by a soul, not even Ferris Doone's dog, which has better eyesight than half this village combined."

Fen inclined his great head, slow and careful, the way a man bows when his own knees have long since forgotten how, and folded himself back out through the hay door into the gray morning, and Branwen stood alone in her studio a long moment with a wheel that still smelled of Tam's damp, resentful clay and a spear back on its pegs exactly where it belonged, and understood, with the flat, settled certainty of a woman who has just watched a door open that she genuinely believed sealed for good, that her quiet life had ended sometime around dawn — and that she was, against every hard-won instinct thirty-one years had ever built into her, glad of it.

Chapter 2: The Thing in the Doorway

Word did not travel as fast as Branwen feared, which she credited less to luck than to the fact that Tam Whistler, age eleven, had spent the entire walk home constructing an increasingly elaborate story about a wolf the size of a cart, and by the time he reached his own kitchen table the wolf had grown a second head, acquired a taste for chickens it had never actually shown, and Ivy had grown bored enough of correcting him to simply let the second head stand uncontested. Their mother, who had heard four separate versions of the Whistler children seeing something enormous over the past two years — a bear, a boar, once memorably a ghost that turned out to be old Ferris Doone walking home from the tavern in a bedsheet after losing a very specific and very public wager — filed the wolf story exactly where she filed the others, somewhere between fondness and mild exasperation, and sent both children to bed early for shouting in the house at an hour decent people were still eating their porridge.

Branwen learned all of this the next morning from Cormac Pell, who told it to her over the counter of his bakery the way he told her nearly everything, without being asked, because thirty years of friendship had worn away whatever thin membrane exists between most people's thoughts and their mouths, leaving Cormac's particular version of that membrane thin as a communion wafer and about as effective at holding anything back.

"Two-headed wolf the size of a cart, with a taste for chicken," Cormac said, sliding a heel of yesterday's bread across the flour-dusted counter, the way he always did, the way that had never once, in four years, felt like the charity it plainly was. "Little Whistler's got a future as a bard, if bards still starved for a living the way they used to in the old songs. Mind, the bread's a day old. Don't tell me it's fine if it isn't, I'll only make more."

"It's fine," Branwen said, and meant it, tearing off a corner while the shop's warm yeast smell settled over her like a second coat against the morning chill. "Terrible business, starving bards."

"Terrible business," Cormac agreed, and did not meet her eyes exactly, which was itself a kind of tell, coming from a man who met everyone's eyes as a matter of course. She kept her own gaze on the bread and hoped

four years of practice not meeting his eyes about other, smaller things had made this particular evasion invisible among the rest.

It hadn't, quite. Cormac had a baker's face, round and weathered and built, over sixty-two years, for kindness rather than sharpness, but underneath the flour and the crinkled warmth was the same watchful attention he'd carried since they were both nineteen years old and he was the only recruit in her cohort who'd ever asked her, unprompted, whether she was frightened, instead of simply assuming the answer for her the way every other boy in the yard had done. He looked at her now the way he'd looked at her then, across a training yard thirty-nine years gone.

"You're doing the thing," he said, wiping flour-dusted hands on an apron that had never, in Branwen's memory, been entirely clean.

"What thing."

"The thing where you know something and you're deciding whether telling me makes it more real." He set the bread knife down, unhurried, giving her the whole of his attention now in a way that made the small shop feel suddenly smaller. "You've done it exactly four times in four years, that I've caught. Once about the kiln fire, the winter you nearly lost the whole studio and told me about it a full week after the fact, like it was old news. Once about the Widow Adler's rent, which you paid yourself out of your own coin and told nobody, and I only found out because she cried about it at market and wouldn't say why until Tamsin got it out of her. Twice about things you never did get around to telling me at all, which I only know exist because I know the shape of you well enough by now to see the gaps where a thing's supposed to sit."

Branwen took the bread properly this time, both hands, and found, standing there in the warm flour-smelling shop with the whole ordinary morning going on outside the window, that she wanted very badly to tell him, and that the wanting frightened her nearly as much as the thing itself did.

"Not today," she said instead. "Ask me again in a week."

Cormac studied her a moment longer, the particular patient study of a man who had learned, across three decades, that pushing Branwen Ashcombe only ever closed doors faster, never opened them sooner. "A week," he agreed, and picked the knife back up, and the moment passed the way most of their moments did, without ceremony, without either of them

needing to make more of it than it already was. "I'm holding you to the number, mind. I'll be counting."



Fen came before sunrise, exactly as told, and exactly as silently — she heard nothing at all until the hay door's leather hinge gave its single soft, apologetic complaint, and turned from banking the kiln's low overnight fire to find him already folded into the bay, smaller somehow in the lamplight, or perhaps only trying harder, this second morning, to seem so.

"You weren't seen," she said. Not quite a question, though she watched his face — such as it was, such expressions as an amber reptile eye could manage — for the answer anyway.

"I came along the river gorge and over the ridge behind the old mill, in the deep dark before even the birds stir. I have had a great deal of practice not being seen, Branwen Ashcombe, across a hundred years of the Guild's ledgers existing in the world." Something in his tone might have been dry humor, if dragons did humor, which she supposed, standing there at half past five in the morning about to teach one to throw a pot, she was going to have to update her assumptions on rather more rapidly than she'd expected.

"Sit," she said, then caught herself, glancing at the vast folded bulk of him. "Or — however it is you manage the version of sitting that suits a body your shape. Here." She'd moved the wheel to the center bay the night before, guessing at his proportions, guessing wrong twice before she found an arrangement that let his enormous foreclaws rest near enough to reach the clay without putting his full weight anywhere near the floorboards she knew, with absolute certainty, would not hold him.

He arranged himself with visible, careful effort, folding down and in, wings drawn tight against his flanks, until his great head was roughly level with hers standing, and his claws — each one longer than her forearm, wickedly curved, entirely unsuited by any design she could imagine to the delicate work she was about to ask of them — hovered above the small lump of gray clay she'd already centered and left waiting on the wheelhead, cool and patient under the lamplight.

"This is going to go badly at first," she told him, plainly, the way she told every new student on their very first morning, whether they were nine years old or fifty-four or, apparently, older than the kingdom's own

recorded history. "Your hands weren't built for this any more than mine were built for centering with two claws where I've got ten fingers, so we're both going to be learning something today, not just you."

"I have killed men with these hands," Fen said, not quite a boast, more a genuine, careful accounting of the odds against them, the way a soldier might list his scars before a difficult march. "I do not know that they can be made gentle."

"Mine have killed dragons," Branwen said. "Let's find out together, before the sun's properly up and one of us loses our nerve."



The first hour taught her more about teaching than it taught Fen about pottery, and taught them both, in the process, exactly how much patience the morning was going to demand of them.

His claws were too long, too rigid, too strong by an order of magnitude that made every gentle correction she offered feel, briefly, like advising a landslide to tread lightly — the first time he set them to the clay and pressed the way she'd shown him, the lump didn't center so much as explode outward, a wet gray spray flung across the wheel, the floorboards, one entire folded wing, which he then had to draw carefully away from the mess with an expression of such profound, wounded embarrassment that Branwen, despite everything, despite the hour and the danger and the sheer wrongness of the whole enterprise, had to turn away and pretend, urgently, to check the water bucket so he wouldn't see her nearly laugh out loud.

"That is not the correct result," Fen said, with enormous, injured dignity, addressing the ruined clay directly as though it might apologize.

"No," Branwen agreed, recovering herself, wiping her mouth with the back of one wrist. "Try less. You keep pressing like you're trying to end an argument before it's properly begun. This isn't an argument, Fen. It's a conversation. The clay talks back, if you let it get a word in."

"I do not know how to do less," Fen said, and there was something under the words that had nothing at all to do with pottery, something worn thin and old, and Branwen — who had spent thirty-one years learning to hear the true shape of a sentence beneath its surface, the way you learn to hear a lie in a green recruit's voice before the recruit himself knows he's about to tell one — heard it perfectly clearly, the whole long grief of it.

"Neither did I," she said. "When I started, four years ago, I broke eleven pots in a row, because I center clay the way I used to grip a spear shaft, which is to say like it's about to try and kill me the second I loosen my grip." She reached over — carefully, aware the whole time of exactly how much damage the claw nearest her hand could do with a single involuntary flinch — and closed her fingers over the topmost joint of his foreclaw, guiding rather than forcing, the scale under her palm cool and dry and rougher than she'd expected, like old harness leather left out in weather. "Here. Feel that? That's the wheel doing the work, not you. You're not fighting it. You're barely touching it at all. Let your whole hand go loose. Let your shoulder go loose. It travels down."

The claw, under her palm, went very still, and then, slowly, softened.

"You are not afraid of me," Fen said. It came out somewhere between a question and a diagnosis, as if he'd been quietly running the calculation the entire hour, watching her hands, her breathing, the set of her shoulders, and had only now finished totaling the sum.

Branwen considered lying. Found, standing there with her whole palm resting over a claw capable of ending her in under a second, that she didn't especially want to, not to him, not on this particular morning.

"I'm afraid of you the way I'm afraid of everything worth being careful around," she said. "Which is to say, constantly, and mostly quietly, somewhere at the back of my skull, and it doesn't stop me doing the thing in front of me anyway." She guided the claw down, slow, onto the wet, spinning clay. "Now. Less. Just — less than you think it needs."

The second lump did not explode. It wobbled, badly, off-center, climbing crookedly into a lopsided cone before collapsing sideways almost immediately into a gray, deflated heap — but it did not explode, and Fen made a sound low in his enormous chest that she recognized, after a startled moment, as something very like a laugh, rough and unpracticed and entirely, unguardedly delighted, a sound she suspected hadn't left that throat in longer than she wanted to think too hard about.

"It didn't break," he said, and there was wonder in it, plain as a child's.

"No," Branwen said, and found she was smiling — an actual smile, the kind that used her whole face rather than the polite, careful fraction she kept in reserve for customers and market-day pleasantries. "It didn't."



They worked until the light through the hay door shifted from gray to the pale gold that meant the village would be stirring soon, carts and roosters and the whole ordinary machinery of a Thistlewick morning grinding slowly back into motion, and Fen — reluctant in a way that plainly surprised even him, an enormous ancient creature dragging his feet like a child called in from play at the very best part of the afternoon — folded himself back toward the hay door with a half-finished, deeply lopsided cylinder wrapped in damp cloth and tucked with absurd, exaggerated care into the crook of one foreleg, as though it might shatter from a harsh look alone.

"Same time tomorrow," Branwen said. It wasn't a question either.

"You would risk it again." Fen paused half in, half out of the doorway, his amber eye catching the first true daylight slanting low across the yard. "Knowing what tomorrow may bring, if we are seen. The Guild. Your village. Everything you've built here, over four years, with your own two hands."

Branwen thought about lying about that too, the way she'd almost lied about being afraid, and found the same thing happening all over again — the truth simply arriving in her mouth, unbidden, before she could construct anything more careful to say instead.

"I don't know what I'm risking yet," she said honestly. "I know what I'd be giving up if I said no, and I've had all night to sit with that particular arithmetic. I've spent four years teaching people how to make things with their hands instead of unmaking them, and I told myself that was the whole of the repair, the whole debt paid. Turns out I hadn't actually tried teaching the one thing I spent thirty years unmaking. Turns out that might matter a good deal more than the rest of it put together." She looked at the cloth-wrapped cylinder cradled in his foreleg, lopsided and cracked along one seam and, by any honest measure, not very good at all. "So yes. Same time tomorrow. Don't make me regret saying so."

Fen inclined his head, the same slow, careful bow, and was gone into the gray morning before the first cart wheels sounded properly on the Thistlewick road, moving with a lightness she hadn't seen in him yet, as though the lopsided cylinder weighed nothing at all against whatever it was actually carrying for him.

Branwen stood in her studio a long moment, listening to the ordinary village wake up around her — a rooster, a dog, somewhere the clatter of Tamsin Vane setting out the inn's morning bread order with rather more noise than the task strictly required — and found her hand had gone, without asking her permission, to the burn scar on her forearm, thumb tracing the old raised line the way it did whenever she was about to say something she didn't especially want to say, except there was no one here to say it to, and the only thing she had to say was to herself, silent, in the empty gold-lit barn: **you have no idea what you've just started.**

She was wrong about that within the hour, though not in the way she'd expected. It was not the Guild that found her first. It was Nell Fairweather, sixteen years old, sweeping the studio's front step at the exact hour she always swept it, rain or shine, dragon or no dragon, who looked at the fresh gouge marks scored deep along the hay-door frame — claw-wide, unmistakable to anyone who'd spent the last two winters devouring every scrap of gossip Thistlewick produced for entertainment the way other girls devoured novels — and said, without preamble, without even setting down her broom, "That's not from a cart horse."

Branwen turned. Nell stood in the doorway, thin and sharp-eyed in the morning light, the particular hard-won wariness of a girl who had learned young, brutally young, that the world took things from you the moment you stopped watching it closely enough, and was not, evidently, about to stop watching now, not for anyone, not even the woman who'd fed her scraps and let her sweep for two winters running.

"No," Branwen agreed, because there was no version of this morning where lying to Nell Fairweather's face ended well for anyone involved, least of all herself. "It isn't."

Nell's eyes went next to the cloth-draped shapes lined up along the drying rack — Fen's ruined first attempts, three of them, none salvageable, all unmistakably shaped by something with claws where fingers ought to be, and beside them the fourth, lopsided but whole, still glistening faintly with damp.

"I want an apprenticeship," Nell said. Flat. Immediate. The bargain already fully formed in her head, the way only a girl who has had very little in her whole life learns to recognize the exact instant real leverage appears and seize it before the moment closes over again like water. "A real one. Not sweeping for scraps and a place to be warm. Wheel time, proper glaze

recipes, my name entered on the register at the guild hall in the capital someday, if I want it, with your name standing behind mine. That's the price of me not saying a single word about whatever just walked out of your hay door on claws the size of my whole forearm."

Branwen looked at her — sixteen and thin and sharp as a wire drawn tight, orphaned by the river two winters back and twice as durable as anyone had any right to expect from that much loss — and felt something that was not quite surprise and not quite relief settle into place in her chest, quiet and certain.

"Done," she said. "Come inside. There's a great deal to explain, and I'd rather you hear the whole shape of it from me than build the wrong story out of claw marks and your own good instincts."

They had gotten exactly three sentences into it — Branwen at the wheel, turning the fourth, salvageable cylinder slowly in her hands as she talked; Nell cross-legged on an upturned crate, listening with the fierce, still attention of someone determined not to miss a single detail; the whole strange, true shape of the morning finally starting to take form in the space between them — when a horn sounded from the direction of the village square, three short notes and one long one, a pattern Branwen's body recognized a full second before her mind caught up and supplied the word for it, cold and immediate as a hand closing round her wrist.

Guild.

Chapter 3: Before Sunrise

The horn's echo hadn't finished dying against the hills before Nell was on her feet, broom abandoned clattering across the doorway, already moving toward the front of the studio like the sound had personally, deliberately offended her.

"Don't," Branwen said, and the single word stopped the girl mid-stride, which told Branwen something useful, filed away for later, about exactly how far Nell's brand-new loyalty already ran after less than a quarter hour of it existing at all. "Whatever that is, we don't run at it, and we don't run from it either. We finish what we're doing and we walk toward it like we've got nothing whatsoever to hide, because right now, out here, this instant, we don't. Fen isn't here. There's wet clay on the wheel and a fortnight's worth of gossip in the square, and that's the whole of what anyone can prove against us."

"And if it's the Guild asking about the wolf story?"

"Then it's the Guild asking about a wolf story, and I've got two ruined pinch pots and a lopsided cylinder to prove that children exaggerate and old dragons don't yet know their own strength." Branwen wiped her hands on her apron, slow, deliberate, the exact unhurried motion she used to put a nervous room at ease before telling it something it didn't especially want to hear. "Sweep the step, Nell. Act like it's a Tuesday. It is a Tuesday. The whole trick of a lie that holds is telling the truth in every particular except the one that matters."

It was, in fact, a Tuesday, ordinary in every visible respect, and by the time Branwen reached the square — walking, not hurrying, nodding to Widow Adler over her market basket and old Ferris Doone leaning in his usual doorway exactly as she did every single morning of her life here — the horn's owner had already dismounted outside the Thistlewick inn, and half the village had gathered at a respectful, curious distance to look at him the way villages always looked at anyone wearing a Guild cloak: somewhere between admiration and the particular wary dread reserved for tax collectors, bad weather, and other unstoppable forces.

He was younger than the cloak made him look from a distance. Twenty-six, twenty-seven — old enough to have properly earned the rank stitched in silver thread at his collar, young enough that he still stood with

the slightly too-straight spine of someone who hadn't yet learned that real authority sits looser on a man than rigid discipline ever could. Sandy hair cropped short under a travel-worn hood gone the color of old rope, a fine white scar threading through one eyebrow that Branwen recognized on sight, recognized in her own fingers before her mind had even finished the thought, because she had been the one to bandage it, nine years ago, after a hasty parry gone wrong on a training field three days' ride from here, the boy white-faced and apologizing even as blood ran into his eye.

He saw her at the same instant she saw him, and something in his whole posture came undone all at once — the careful readiness dropping straight out of his shoulders, replaced by an expression of such open, uncomplicated delight that half the watching villagers visibly relaxed on the spot, deciding whatever this was, it surely couldn't be dangerous if the Guild man was grinning like a boy let out early from his lessons.

"Master Ashcombe." He caught himself almost at once, laughing softly, and corrected it. "Sorry — force of habit, ten years deep. Branwen."

"Perrin Doyle." She said it flatly, deliberately, but something in her chest had gone tight and complicated in a way that had nothing whatsoever to do with the fear she'd braced herself for on the walk over. "You've got a captain's collar now, I see. Last I laid eyes on you, you still owed me for that eyebrow, and a fair bit of ale besides, if memory serves."

"I've owed you for a great deal more than the eyebrow and the ale combined, and we both know it better than anyone else standing in this square." Perrin crossed the last few feet between them and, before she could decide whether to permit it, pulled her into a quick, hard embrace, the particular unselfconscious kind old comrades give each other in doorways and market squares, entirely unconcerned with who might be watching or what they might make of it. He smelled of horse and road-dust and, underneath both, faintly of the oil the Guild used to keep its ceremonial blades from tarnishing, a smell that dropped Branwen fifteen years backward, in a single unwelcome breath, into a training yard she had not thought about in longer than she'd realized until just now. "You look well. You look — " he pulled back, considered her properly, openly, the way a man looks at someone he genuinely, gladly hadn't expected to find happy, "—you look like retirement agrees with you a great deal better than I ever imagined it would, the day you left."

"It does," she said, keeping her voice easy, keeping her face doing the ordinary friendly work a face does when an old student turns up unannounced after nine long years, and underneath every single word she was running the calculation she'd run a thousand times in the field, in a hundred different villages: *what does he know, what does he suspect, what does he want, and in exactly what order.* "What brings a Guild captain all the way to Thistlewick? We don't usually rate the visit. Last time the Guild sent anyone through here, it was to collect a tithe, and even then they sent a clerk."

Perrin's easy grin dimmed a fraction, and the careful readiness crept back into his shoulders, and Branwen understood, watching it happen in real time, that whatever sat underneath this particular visit was not a small thing to him, whatever else it was.

"Sightings," he said. "Three separate reports out of the eastern hills in the last fortnight alone. A scorched hedge near the old mill, patchy and strange, not like any lightning strike the farmer there had ever seen before. A man two valleys over swears something the size of a house crossed the ridge at dawn, low and fast, gone before he could properly focus on it. And now, apparently — " his eyes flicked, briefly, meaningfully, toward the knot of villagers still watching them from a respectful distance, "—a two-headed wolf the size of a cart with a taste for chicken, according to the youngest Whistler boy, who I gather has something of a reputation in this village already."

"He does," Branwen agreed. "Reliable as a broken clock. He once told the entire schoolyard a ghost had stolen his boots clean off his feet in the night. It was Ferris Doone's dog, which had simply taken a liking to the leather."

"I'd love to believe that's the whole of it here too." Perrin's voice dropped, quiet enough now that it plainly wasn't meant for the square any longer. "But there's an open contract still on the Guild's books, Branwen. Eastern range, the last name among the eleven you never formally closed before you retired. I've been sent out to confirm whether it's live, or whether it's thirty years of an old grudge and a mischievous boy's imagination getting tangled together in everyone's mind. I was hoping — " and here the openness came flooding back into his face, the genuine, uncomplicated warmth of a man who had trained under her for six years and trusted her judgment more, if he was honest, than he trusted his own

instructions from the capital, "—I was hoping you'd help me rule it out quickly and cleanly, so I can write an honest report and go home, and you can get back to whatever this new life is." He gestured, vaguely, warmly, at the pale clay dust still ground into the creases of her hands. "Pottery. Of all the things in this wide world you might have chosen. I still can't quite credit it, even standing here looking at the evidence."

Branwen looked at her own hands — clay under every nail, a fresh scrape along one knuckle from that morning's careful, patient guiding of a claw twice the size of her whole forearm — and did something she had not done to Perrin Doyle in fifteen years of knowing him, not once, not even the time she'd sent him into a fight she privately, quietly believed he might not walk away from.

She lied to him. Cleanly, steadily, without her voice moving a single hair's-breadth from its ordinary, easy register.

"I haven't seen or heard a thing out here beyond hedge fires and Tam Whistler's overactive imagination," she said. "But if it'll help set your report straight, you're welcome to search the hills as thoroughly as you like. I know them better than anyone left in this village, if you'd want the company. It's been a long while since I walked them for anything but mushrooms and firewood."

Something in Perrin's face eased at that, trusting, grateful, entirely unsuspecting, and the sight of it settled into Branwen's stomach like a stone dropped into still water, sending rings out long after the stone itself had gone silent and still on the bottom.

"I'd like that," he said. "Tomorrow, if you're willing? I want a proper night's sleep that isn't spent on the road first, and a hot meal that isn't trail bread."

"Tomorrow," Branwen agreed, and felt the single small word cost her something she didn't yet have a proper name for.



She did not go back to the studio directly. She walked the long way instead, past the mill's slow-turning wheel, past the river gorge where Fen had told her he'd crossed unseen in the deep dark, and stood a long while at the ridge above it with her arms crossed hard against her own chest and her mind turning over, again and again, the exact shape of the lie she'd just told

and the exact shape of the promise she'd made the morning before, and found, uncomfortably, standing there with the wind pulling at her hair, that both shapes were precisely the same size, and pointed in stubbornly opposite directions, and she did not yet know how to make them agree.

Fen was waiting for her when she finally returned near midday, folded into the deep shadow of the hay bay in broad daylight, which was itself a risk she hadn't authorized and said so, sharply, the moment she caught sight of him.

"I heard the horn from the ridge path, clear across the valley," Fen said, before she could finish the reprimand properly. "I came to see whether I needed to leave Thistlewick tonight and never return to trouble you again. It seemed a conversation better had in person than left to speculation and worry on both our parts."

"His name is Perrin Doyle," Branwen said, dropping onto the low stool without ceremony, suddenly, entirely tired. "He was my student, once, for six good years. He's a decent man, genuinely decent, and he's got an open contract in his saddlebag with your exact description written on it, and tomorrow he wants me to help him search these very hills to close it out for good." She rubbed her thumb hard along the scar on her forearm, the motion entirely unconscious, entirely automatic. "I lied to him. Today. Straight to his open, honest face, and I didn't so much as blink doing it, and I've been standing on that ridge the better part of an hour since, trying to work out exactly what that says about the woman I've become."

"It says you have decided something," Fen said, with the particular flat, unhurried clarity of a creature who had spent a very long life watching decisions get made all around him, by frightened men with spears and frightened councils with ledgers, and had learned, across all those long years, to read the shape of a decision before the person making it had fully admitted to it themselves. "You have not yet decided whether you regret it. That is a different question entirely, and I suspect it will take you longer to answer than the first one did."

"No," Branwen admitted, into the quiet. "I haven't. Not yet."

They stood together a long moment in the hay bay's dim gold light, the enormous ancient dragon and the retired slayer, and outside the ordinary sounds of Thistlewick's afternoon carried on entirely unaware that anything in the village had shifted at all — a cart creaking past, a dog's

half-hearted bark, Tamsin Vane's voice raised somewhere in cheerful, practiced argument with a delivery boy over the fair price of barley, three streets over and a whole world away from this quiet, dust-thick barn.

"Tomorrow," Branwen said finally, "you don't come. Not before sunrise, not after, not for any reason short of the barn itself burning down around your ears. Not until I know exactly where Perrin's search is taking us tomorrow, and exactly how long he means to stay after."

"You are frightened," Fen observed, not unkindly, in the tone of a man simply naming weather.

"I mean it," Branwen went on, ignoring the observation because agreeing with it would have cost her something she didn't have spare just now. "If he finds you before I've found a way through this — through the both of you, through what you are and what he's carrying and what the whole village might do with either fact once it gets loose — it isn't a contract closing on some creature he's never met and can't picture. It's a contract closing on you, in front of me, and I don't know what I'd do in that moment, and I would very much prefer, for both our sakes, to never once find out."

"Nor would I," Fen said, with a dryness that might, again, have been humor, if the words beneath it hadn't been so plainly, quietly frightened themselves. "I will wait. I am old, Branwen Ashcombe. I have had a very great deal of practice at waiting, more than any creature ought to need." He paused at the hay door, wings already drawing tight for the fold through it, and looked back at her once more. "For what small measure it is worth — I am glad you lied for me today. I did not expect to be glad of such a thing, given precisely how it was earned between us in the first place, eleven of my own kind deep."

He was gone before she could find any answer worth giving, and it was just as well, because she genuinely did not yet have one.

Chapter 4: A Face From the Guild Roster

Nell was waiting on the studio step when Branwen finally returned near dusk, arms wrapped tight around her knees, the broom leaned forgotten against the doorframe exactly where she'd abandoned it that morning, straw bristles gathering dust she'd normally never have let sit that long.

"You never finished telling me," Nell said, without preamble, in the flat, aggrieved tone of someone who had spent an entire long day turning a half-explained secret over and over in her mind and liking it less with every single turn. "You said there was a lot to explain and then a horn went off and you left, and I've spent the whole day guarding a hay door full of claw marks and pretending to sweep a step that's been clean since noon."

Branwen sat down on the step beside her, which she almost never did, because sitting on the step meant a conversation was going to take its time, and she generally preferred to have her hard conversations upright, where she could end one simply by standing. But the day had run long and strange, and the girl beside her had earned considerably better than being managed from a height.

"His name is Fen," Branwen said. "He's a dragon. The last one left in the eastern range, if he's telling the truth, and I've no particular reason yet to think he isn't. He wants to learn to make pottery before he dies, because in a very long, very violent life he's never once made a single thing that wasn't a memory of fire, and I understand that better than I'd like to admit to anyone, including myself." She let that settle a moment in the cooling evening air. "And this morning a Guild captain rode into the square with an open contract that matches Fen's description exactly, down to the scarring, and I lied to his face about ever having seen anything at all, and tomorrow I'm meant to help him search these very hills to prove the contract's dead so he can write his report and ride home satisfied."

Nell was quiet for a long moment, turning it all over with the same wary, methodical thoroughness she turned over everything that mattered — a girl who had learned, at fourteen, standing knee-deep in the wreckage of a flood that had taken both her parents and half her street in a single terrible night, that the world rarely handed you the whole truth on its first pass, and that the real, useful information almost always lived in whatever came after.

"Are you going to give him up?" she asked, finally, flat, not accusing, simply needing the shape of the answer settled before she decided what to do with any of the rest of it.

"No," Branwen said, and was faintly, quietly surprised by how little the word cost her the second time she said it aloud, compared to how much the very first lie had cost her that morning in the square. "I don't know yet how I'm going to stop what's coming. But no. Not him. Not while I've got breath and any say in the matter at all."

Something in Nell's shoulders came down a full inch at that, tension the girl had apparently been carrying, unspoken, since the horn first sounded. "Good," she said. "Because I'd already decided this morning I wasn't going to apprentice myself to a woman who'd hand something over just because a man in a nice cloak asked politely enough and smiled the right way while doing it."

"You'd decided that before you knew any of the actual particulars."

"I decide most things before I know all of the particulars," Nell said, entirely unbothered by the admission. "It's faster, and I'm usually right, and when I'm wrong I fix it quick before it costs anyone anything real." She stood, brushed off her skirts with brisk efficiency, and picked the broom back up with the businesslike air of someone returning at last to unfinished work she took seriously. "What do you need from me. For tomorrow, and for the search, and for whatever comes crawling out of the woodwork after that."

Branwen looked up at her — sixteen and thin and utterly unshaken by the single largest, most dangerous secret Thistlewick had held in a full generation — and felt something settle quietly into place that she hadn't expected to feel today, underneath all the fear and the calculation: something that was almost, cautiously, tentatively like not being entirely alone in carrying it.

"For tomorrow," she said, "you keep the studio running exactly as it always runs, not a hair different. Lessons on schedule. Nothing hidden differently than it was hidden yesterday, because a sudden change is the surest way to draw exactly the eyes we're trying to avoid. If anyone asks where I am, I'm out walking the hills with an old student, catching up on old times over ale and memory — which happens to also be, conveniently, entirely true." She stood too, her joints protesting faintly, the long day's

walk to the ridge and back settling into her hips the way it never used to when she was younger and considerably more foolish about her own limits. "And you don't go near the hay door alone after dark until I tell you plainly it's safe. Not because I don't trust you, Nell. Because if this whole thing goes wrong, I want as much distance between you and the wreckage as I can possibly manage to put there."

Nell's jaw set, the particular stubborn set Branwen was already coming to recognize as the girl's own private version of an argument she'd decided, for now, not to have out loud. "Fine," she said. "For now. Don't think that means forever."



The hill search took the better part of two full days, and Branwen spent both of them doing something she had once been extraordinarily, professionally good at and had genuinely hoped never to need to do again: reading a landscape closely for the signs of a creature she had absolutely no intention of ever letting be found.

It was not difficult, exactly — thirty-one years had taught her every trick a dragon used to stay hidden in open country, which meant she knew, with precise and unwelcome intimacy, exactly which places to lead Perrin's search past and exactly which false signs to point him toward instead, casually, as though the thought had only just occurred to her. The scorched hedge, she told him with total, easy confidence, kneeling to examine the blackened branches with a practiced eye, was old lightning-strike damage, weathered strangely wrong by a wet summer that had softened and spread the scarring. The house-sized shape crossing the ridge at dawn was, in all likelihood, the shadow of a low, fast-moving cloud caught at exactly the wrong angle — the kind of trick of light and distance that had started a hundred dragon rumors over the long centuries and had turned out, every single time she'd personally investigated one in her working years, to be nothing more than weather doing what weather does. Perrin, to his considerable credit, was a careful and thorough searcher, methodical in a way that would have made her genuinely proud of him under any other circumstances in the world, and it was precisely that thoroughness that made lying to him exhausting in a way lying to Odger Crabbe or the Whistler children never would have been, because Perrin checked things. Perrin asked good, sharp questions, the kind she'd trained into him herself. Perrin, twice over the two days, looked at her sideways

with an expression she recognized from her own training-yard days decades ago, the particular look of a student who has caught his teacher in a half-truth and is deciding, purely out of long-held respect, not to press it just yet.

"You're very certain about the hedge," he said, on the second evening, as they made camp in the lee of the ridge with the fire built low and careful the exact way she'd taught him a decade and a half ago, when he'd been sixteen and clumsy and terrified of every shadow in the wood. "For someone who claims not to have been out this particular way in months."

"I walk these hills most weeks of my life," Branwen said, which was true, entirely true, and let the honest weight of it carry whatever lie sat quietly beneath it. "I know lightning damage when I see it up close. I've seen enough of it over the years to know its moods."

Perrin studied her across the fire a long moment, the flames throwing his scarred eyebrow into sharp, flickering relief, and something in his face — not quite suspicion, something gentler and considerably worse, something closer to worry — settled there and, this time, stayed put.

"You know," he said slowly, poking at the fire without really looking at it, "when the Guild first told me the report had come out of Thistlewick, I was glad of it. I thought, well, if there's anything real to it at all, at least Branwen Ashcombe is out there already, on the ground, and if anyone alive can tell a genuine threat from a farmer's overactive imagination and a trick of the light, it's her." He looked up at her now, direct, unguarded. "I didn't expect to spend two whole days wondering whether the reason you're so very certain of every single thing we've found is that you already know exactly what it is, and exactly where it isn't, and have from the very first moment I rode into your square."

The stone in Branwen's stomach, which had been sitting quiet and heavy since the square, turned over once, cold and unwelcome, all the way through.

"Perrin—"

"I'm not asking you to tell me anything you don't want to," he said, quickly, holding up one open hand, and there was something almost pleading in the gesture, an old student asking his old teacher not to force him into choosing between his written instructions and his own hard-won instincts before he absolutely had to. "I'm asking you to remember that

whatever this is — if it's anything at all — I would rather hear it plainly from you than go and find it myself, alone, without your guidance. Because if I find it on my own, I don't get to choose how I report it. If you tell me, together, we might have options neither of us has thought of yet, sitting here by this fire."

Branwen looked into the low flames, and at the honest, worried face of the boy she'd once trained and bandaged and sent into battles she'd privately prayed, every single time, that he would survive, and felt the lie she'd been carrying for two solid days grow heavier and more unsustainable with every passing hour, the way a wet garment grows heavier the longer you keep wearing it, pretending it isn't soaking straight through to the skin.

"Give me time," she said, finally, which was not quite the whole truth and not quite a lie either, a particular kind of half-answer she was becoming uncomfortably practiced at manufacturing on short notice. "There's more to this than a hedge fire and a cloud's shadow, Perrin. I won't insult either of us any longer by pretending otherwise. But I need time to be certain exactly what I'm asking you to risk before I go and ask you to risk it, knowingly, with your eyes open."

Perrin held her gaze a long moment across the low, guttering fire, and something passed between them that was old and mutual and built, brick by brick, on fifteen years of trust that neither of them had ever once had cause to seriously question before this particular week.

"Tomorrow," he said finally, quiet, "I'll search the last stretch of the eastern ridge alone, since you've a studio to run and I've already taken more of your time than I had any right to ask for. And when I get back down to Thistlewick, I'm going to sit down and write my report." He paused, the fire popping softly between them. "How long is enough time, Branwen? Truly. I need something more solid to carry than *soon.*"

"I don't know yet," she admitted, and meant it entirely. "But less than you'd like, and more than I'd like. That's the honest truth of it, for now, and it's all I've got to offer you tonight."

He nodded, slow, and did not press any further, and they sat either side of the low fire in a silence that was not quite comfortable but was not yet broken either — two people who trusted each other deeply, standing on

opposite sides of a line neither of them had drawn on purpose, both of them watching, carefully, to see which way it was finally going to move.

Chapter 5: What the Contract Says

The Thistlewick inn smelled, as it always did at midmorning, of yesterday's ale gone faintly stale under the counter and today's bread rising warm above it, a combination Tamsin Vane had once cheerfully described as "the whole personality of this place bottled and served fresh daily, take it or leave it." Branwen found Perrin at the corner table nearest the good window, a stack of papers laid out in front of him and weighted down against the draft with an empty mug, and Tamsin hovering nearby with the particular attentive hospitality she reserved for guests she found genuinely interesting, which in Thistlewick's case meant nearly all of them, since so very few strangers ever bothered to pass through at all.

"Branwen!" Tamsin's whole face lit up, the way it always did, warm and open and entirely without guile, and she pulled out the third chair before Branwen had even finished crossing the room. "Sit, sit, sit. Captain Doyle's been telling me all about the eastern posting, and I've been telling him absolutely everything wrong about you in return, so you'd best come correct the record before it sets too hard to fix."

"There's a record in need of correcting?" Branwen sat, glancing at the papers pinned beneath Perrin's mug, upside-down from her angle but the official Guild letterhead unmistakable even reversed, the seal pressed deep into the wax corner catching the window light.

"I told him about the roof," Tamsin said, already pouring a third mug from the pot balanced on her hip without being asked at all, because after four years she'd stopped asking and simply started knowing, the way she knew half the village's business before the village itself had finished deciding what its business was. "The winter the river came up over its banks in the night and took half the Miller Street roofs clean off with it. Told him it was you who organized the rebuilding, start to finish, not the alderman, though Odger does love telling it different whenever the subject comes up at meetings."

"Cormac organized the rebuilding," Branwen said. "I held ladders and carried timber."

"You held ladders for eleven straight days without once sleeping in your own bed, and you paid for the lumber on four of the six roofs entirely out of your own coin, and don't you dare think the whole village doesn't

know it by now, even if you've never once said so yourself in all this time." Tamsin set the mug down with the particular finality of a woman closing an argument she considered already thoroughly won, and bustled off toward the kitchen with the brisk air of someone who had delivered exactly the information she'd meant to deliver and had no further need whatsoever to linger over it.

Perrin watched her go, then looked back at Branwen with an expression that had gathered something new to it since the hillside two nights past — not quite suspicion, but a kind of careful, deliberate weighing, as if he were adding Tamsin's small story to a private ledger he'd apparently been keeping ever since he first rode into the square.

"You never mentioned the flood," he said.

"You never asked about floods. You asked about dragons, and I answered the question that was actually put to me."

"Fair enough." A faint, tired smile, more in the eyes than the mouth. He pulled the mug off the stack of papers and slid the top sheet across the table toward her, and Branwen felt her whole body go still and careful in the particular, practiced way it used to go still right before a fight, though there was no fight here at all, only paper and old ink and a decision waiting to be made. "I want to show you something. Not because I think it'll change a single thing you've already quietly decided not to tell me. Because I think you deserve to see exactly what it is I'm carrying in this satchel before either of us decides what to do about any of it."

The paper was old — older than Perrin's own captaincy, older, Branwen realized with a slow, cold certainty as she read down the header, than his entire time in the Guild's service. *Contract of Engagement, Eastern Range, Standing Order,* and below it, in the flat, colorless bureaucratic language the Guild used indiscriminately for everything from supply requisitions to death warrants, a description: *the last dragon of the eastern range, gold-green coloration, estimated age exceeding one century, wing-scarring consistent with prior engagement, believed responsible for the Ashgrove burning.*

"This was never closed," Branwen said. It wasn't a question. She remembered the Ashgrove burning — remembered it, in fact, from the other side entirely, remembered standing in its smoking wreckage some twenty-odd years ago, young and furious and absolutely certain of her own

righteousness, and remembered, too, being called away before the contract on its perpetrator was ever formally resolved, reassigned at short notice to a border skirmish that had seemed, at the time, considerably more urgent than chasing one grieving, frightened creature across a ruined valley.

"No," Perrin said. "It sat quietly in the Guild's standing files for over two full decades, because nobody could ever confirm the creature was even still alive out there, and a contract with no confirmed living target doesn't get formally closed — it just goes... quiet. Until someone reports a sighting in the right range with the right matching description, and then, all at once, it stops being quiet at all." He tapped the description with one finger, not unkindly, but with the plain, unmistakable weight of a man laying out facts he genuinely wished, sitting there, were different than they were. "Gold-green. Wing-scarring, consistent. The exact profile, Branwen, down to the last detail. If whatever's out there in your hills matches this description, it isn't a new contract someone has to sit down and write from scratch. It's an old one, already signed, already authorized at the highest level the Guild has, simply waiting, patiently, for the right officer to confirm the target and execute it as ordered."

Branwen's hand had gone, without her permission, to the scar on her forearm, thumb pressing hard along the old raised line. "The Ashgrove burning," she said slowly, "happened because a young, terrified creature was defending a nest that the Guild had already located and marked for a raid, weeks before the burning itself. I know this because I was the one who found the original nest report myself, buried in the files, years too late to do a single useful thing about it, and I never told a soul because there was no one left standing who I believed would actually care to hear it." She looked up at Perrin, and let him see, for the very first time since he'd ridden into her square, exactly how much all of this was costing her to say out loud. "Whoever's out there in these hills didn't start that fire for sport, Perrin. He started it because we came for his family first, and burned them out of their own home before he ever raised a single flame against ours."

Perrin went very quiet, the papers entirely forgotten beneath his still hand, and something in his face — the careful weighing, the private ledger he'd been keeping since the square — tipped, visibly, all at once, toward a conclusion Branwen hadn't dared to hope he might reach entirely on his own.

"You know it's a *he,*" he said softly. "You just told me something you couldn't possibly know unless you'd spoken with it yourself, face to face."

The stone in Branwen's stomach dropped straight through the floor.

She had not meant to say it. Thirty-one years of careful, controlled speech, of measuring every word before it left her mouth in rooms far more dangerous than this one, and she had let the plain truth walk straight out past every single guard she'd carefully set for it, because the sheer injustice of the old contract had mattered to her, in that unguarded moment, more than the danger of the confession itself — and now it sat between them on the table beside the Guild's own letterhead, plain and unrecoverable and entirely, irrevocably said.

"Perrin," she said. "Before you write down another single word—"

"I haven't written anything," he said, quickly, and there was something almost desperate in it, an old student reaching across the table for his teacher's hand before either of them went over the edge together. "I haven't sent anything to anyone. I came here to search these hills honestly, and I found you instead, and I have spent two full days watching you lie to me with more visible care than I've ever once seen you put into anything, except perhaps keeping a green recruit alive on his first real campaign. And I think — " he stopped, started again, quieter this time, gentler, "—I think you found something out in these hills that isn't remotely what the Guild believes it to be. And I think you'd rather trust me with the whole truth of it than trust the Guild's paperwork to be fair to it, given everything you've just told me about how that paperwork was written in the first place. So. Tell me. Not as a captain sitting across this table from you. As the boy whose eyebrow you stitched shut on a training field, because the surgeon was three fields over and you refused to make me wait."

Branwen looked at him a long moment — at the earnest, worried, fundamentally decent face of a man who had spent his whole young career inside a system deliberately built to make exactly this kind of mercy as difficult as possible to extend — and made, at that corner table, with Tamsin's kettle whistling faintly somewhere behind the kitchen door and the whole ordinary noise of Thistlewick's morning carrying on outside the window, the second real, irreversible decision of her entire retirement.

"His name is Fen," she said. "And before I tell you another single word beyond that, I need you to understand exactly what you're choosing, sitting

here listening to me say that name out loud, because once I've said it properly, you don't get to un-know it afterward, and neither, from this moment forward, do I."

Chapter 6: Second Lesson

Perrin did not run. That was the thing Branwen turned over and over in her mind while she led him out along the river gorge in the last violet hour before true dark, watching his shoulders for the particular set that meant a man was thinking hard about his sword — watching, and finding none of it, only the tight, careful posture of someone walking deliberately toward a conversation he badly, visibly wanted to survive whole.

"You understand," she said, low, as they climbed the last rise before the old mill, gravel shifting underfoot in the failing light, "that what I'm about to show you could end your career if you handle it wrong, in either direction. Mine too. Possibly the entire village's charter, if Odger Crabbe ever gets wind of how deep this actually goes before I've had a chance to manage it properly."

"I understood that the moment you said his name at that table," Perrin said. His breath fogged faintly in the cooling air. "I've had the better part of an hour to sit with it since. I'm still walking beside you, aren't I."

Fen was waiting in the lee of the mill's collapsed wheel, further out from the studio than Branwen had told him to range, which told her something about how closely he'd been listening for that horn all week, and how badly he'd wanted to be near enough to help if the sound of real trouble ever came. He rose out of the deep shadow slowly, deliberately, every motion telegraphed the exact way you'd move in front of a spooked, dangerous animal — and Perrin, to his very great credit, to the credit of six years of her own training finally paying out in precisely the moment she needed it to, did not draw.

He went very still instead. Both hands visible, open, held carefully away from his hilt. His breath came fast and shallow for three, four full seconds, the pure animal response of a hundred generations of story finally standing in front of him made flesh and scale and breath, and then, visibly, deliberately, he made himself breathe slower, the way she'd drilled into green recruits for fifteen straight years: **fear is information, not instruction.**

"Captain Perrin Doyle," Fen said, inclining his great head with the same slow care he'd shown Branwen on that very first morning. "I am

given to understand you carry a contract with my description on it, in the satchel at your hip."

"I do." Perrin's voice shook, only slightly, and he did not try to hide the shaking, which struck Branwen, watching, as its own quiet kind of courage. "I was told the target was responsible for the Ashgrove burning."

"I was," Fen said. No evasion in it at all, no softening. "I do not ask you to forgive that. I ask only that you know the whole shape of it before you decide what it means, and what it does not." And he told it — the nest, hidden three days' climb above the valley floor, the raid the Guild had authorized without ever confirming what actually lived there, the fire that had come after, not before, born of grief rather than malice — in the same halting, unpracticed rasp he'd used to ask Branwen for a lesson three weeks past, and Branwen watched Perrin's face move through disbelief and horror and, finally, something that looked uncomfortably, unmistakably like recognition — the particular sick recognition of a man realizing, in real time, that an organization he'd given the whole of his working life to had once done something wholly indefensible, and had simply never told anyone loudly enough for the story to survive past its own official silence.

"That's not in the file," he said, when Fen finished. His voice had gone rough, scraped thin. "None of that is anywhere in the file I carry. The file just says *responsible for the Ashgrove burning,* full stop, like it happened out of nothing at all, for no reason a reasonable creature could ever hold."

"Files rarely trouble themselves with reasons," Fen said. "Reasons complicate the ledger, and ledgers prefer to stay simple, so the numbers add up clean at the end of the season."

Perrin looked at Branwen, and there was something raw and unmoored in his face now, a young man's very first real look at the gap between the organization he'd sworn himself to and the tidy story it told about its own history. "What do I do with this?" he asked, and the question came out smaller than she'd ever heard him ask anything, even as a green recruit. "I can't un-write the contract. I don't have anything close to that authority. I can delay my own report. I can't make the thing itself simply disappear."

"Nobody is asking you to make it disappear," Branwen said. "Tonight, we're only asking you to sit here and watch him make a bowl, and decide for yourself, with your own two eyes, whether the creature in front of you

is a genuine threat to this kingdom, or an old, grieving thing who wants one gentle piece of work before he dies of age or grief, whichever comes for him first." She looked between them — her old student and the last dragon of the eastern range, standing together in the broken shadow of a mill in the deepening dark, each of them carrying more history between them than either had ever asked to hold. "That's the whole of what tonight is for, Perrin. Just look. Nothing more is required of you yet."



They did not go to the studio itself. Too great a risk with Odger Crabbe's evening rounds still the better part of an hour from finished, and half the village's windows still lit warm against the coming dark. Instead Branwen sent Nell running ahead with a shuttered lamp and a spare lump of clay wrapped tight in damp cloth, and the three of them — an old slayer, a young captain, and the very last of his kind — settled together in the hollow behind the mill wheel while Fen, watched by lamplight and by a man who held, at that moment, every legal right in the kingdom to end him where he crouched, worked a lump of river clay between two enormous claws with a care that had grown, over three short weeks of practice, from clumsy, dangerous violence into something approaching real tenderness.

"He huffs," Branwen told Perrin quietly, as Fen's breath, held a beat too long in concentration, escaped in a small anxious gust that scorched a thin black line along the clay's rising rim. "Every single time he concentrates too hard, without fail. Breathe slower," she called across to Fen, without once looking away from the wheel's slow spin. "You're not fighting the clay. You're not fighting anything at all tonight. Slow."

Fen's breath evened out, audibly, deliberately. The scorched line stayed where it was, a small dark blemish neither of them moved to smooth away, and the bowl beneath his careful claws kept rising, wobbling, unmistakably imperfect, undeniably a bowl all the same, taking its shape in the low lamplight while a Guild captain watched on with his hands open and empty in his lap and something on his face that had, somewhere in the last quarter hour, entirely stopped being fear.

"I don't understand how you do that," Perrin said, to Branwen, very quietly, as if raising his voice at all might somehow break whatever fragile thing was happening at the wheel. "Teach, I mean. I watched you unmake

things, methodically, for six straight years of my life. I never once saw you build a single thing in all that time."

"I didn't know I could, until I actually tried it myself," Branwen said. "Turns out the hands remember whichever job you give them most recently, and forget, eventually, mostly, whichever job came before. Give them enough new work to do, and the old work starts to fade at the edges, like ink left too long in the sun." She glanced down at her own scarred forearm without quite meaning to. "Not entirely, mind you. Never entirely. But mostly, on the good days."

Fen's bowl wobbled, steadied, wobbled once more — and this time did not collapse. He lifted his claws away from it with the exaggerated, deliberate care of a man setting down something he genuinely believed might explode, and the four walls of clay stood, uneven and cracked faintly along one seam, entirely, gloriously intact: the first thing in this whole strange enterprise that had survived clean from beginning to end without a single true break.

"It held," Fen said, and there was wonder in it, plain and unguarded and entirely without artifice, a hundred years of a very long, very violent existence compressed down into two small, astonished words.

"It held," Branwen agreed, and found, watching him turn the small bowl slowly in the lamplight, that her own throat had gone tight in a way she hadn't quite expected and didn't especially want to examine too closely with an audience present, however sympathetic that audience had proven itself tonight.

Perrin was quiet a long moment, looking at the small imperfect bowl sitting between them in the lamplight, and when he finally spoke his voice had lost every last trace of the careful, neutral captain's register he'd worn since first riding into the square four days past.

"Why did you quit?" he asked Branwen, abruptly, the question arriving sideways, the way genuinely honest questions sometimes do when a man's guard has finally, fully come down. "Killing them, I mean. You never once told me, in all the years I served under you. You simply left the Guild one autumn without a word of warning, and the next thing anyone in the ranks heard, you'd bought a sheep barn out in Thistlewick and started teaching children to make cups."

Branwen looked at the bowl, at Fen's careful, hopeful, watchful eye fixed steadily on her, at Perrin's open, honest face waiting patiently for an answer she'd genuinely never given another living soul — not Cormac, not Tamsin, not even herself, in the quiet, restless hours when she lay awake turning the question over and over like a stone worn smooth from handling.

"I killed a dragon outside a place called Millbrook," she said slowly, the words coming up from somewhere she hadn't visited in years, "and afterward, going through what it had been guarding so fiercely, I found half-built things. Not weapons. Not a hoard of gold and old bones, the way the songs always tell it. Small clay things, badly made, crooked, the exact kind of thing a creature makes when it's teaching itself entirely alone, with no one at all to show it how it's properly done. I never learned its name. I'd killed forty of them by then and I couldn't remember a single face among the lot, not one, but I remembered every wingbeat, every parry, every clean kill shot with perfect, terrible precision, as though my hands had kept a ledger my own mind had quietly refused to. And I stood there in that cold cave holding a broken clay cup some creature had made entirely alone in the dark, with no one ever once showing it how, and I understood, all at once, standing there, that I'd spent thirty-one years becoming extraordinarily good at ending things I had never once, in all that time, tried to actually understand."

She looked up, met Fen's ancient, patient eye steadily, and found she could say the rest of it now, evenly, for the very first time in her life.

"I didn't quit because I felt guilty enough to finally stop. I quit because I realized, standing in that cave, that I didn't know how to be anything else, and I was tired — bone-tired, all the way through — of being the only thing I'd ever learned how to be."

The fire crackled low and steady between them. Somewhere beyond the mill's broken silhouette, an owl called once into the dark and went quiet again, and Fen's great head bowed, slow, the same careful bow he always gave, and this time there was nothing apologetic in it at all — only a kind of grave, settled gratitude.

"Thank you," he said, "for telling that to him tonight, and not only to me, alone, in the dark where it costs you less."

Perrin didn't speak for a long moment. When he finally did, his voice had gone rough in a way Branwen hadn't heard from him since the training field, since the eyebrow, since he'd been young enough to cry openly over a wound without any shame at all, and old enough, even then, to be quietly ashamed of doing it anyway in front of the other recruits.

"I don't know what I'm going to write in my report," he admitted, turning his mug slowly between his hands without drinking from it. "I genuinely don't, and that frightens me more than the creature sitting three feet from me ever could. But it isn't going to be tonight's report, whatever I finally decide. Tonight didn't happen yet, as far as the Guild's concerned, and it isn't going to, not until I've had proper time to think it through." He looked once more at Fen's small, imperfect, gloriously intact bowl. "Give me time to think, the same way you asked him to give you time, back in the square. That's the only honest thing I have left to offer either of you tonight."

Chapter 7: Village Talk

Odger Crabbe called the village meeting for the evening after next, and he called it the way he called every meeting in his eleven years as alderman: reluctantly, apologetically, and with the deep, abiding conviction that failing to call it would somehow prove worse in the end than calling it ever could.

"It's not that I believe the boy's wolf story, mind," he told Cormac, in the bread queue outside the bakery that morning, in a voice pitched to carry to exactly the people he wanted it to carry to and not one soul further, a skill Branwen had always privately admired even on the occasions its target proved inconvenient to her own purposes. "It's that three separate reports inside a single fortnight is three more than we've had in the whole eleven years I've held this office, and if the Guild comes back through here a second time and finds we never so much as properly discussed it as a village, that reflects poorly on the charter, Cormac. You know precisely how the capital thinks about villages that can't manage their own small affairs without prompting."

"I know how you think about the capital thinking about us," Cormac said, mild as milk, handing over a loaf without being asked at all, because he'd been selling Odger the very same loaf at the very same hour for the better part of a decade and had long since stopped pretending it required actual words between them. "Half of your three reports were a hedge and a cloud's shadow, Odger. The other half was Tam Whistler's wolf, which now, I gather, has two heads and a taste for chicken, if you're keeping careful count of the details as they multiply."

"I am keeping careful count," Odger said, with real feeling. "That's rather the whole trouble, if I'm honest with you."

Branwen heard the entire exchange from three places back in the queue and said absolutely nothing, which had become, over the preceding week, an increasingly demanding kind of nothing to maintain — the specific, effortful silence of a woman holding an entire secret behind her teeth while it strained against them, steadily, like a dog leaning hard into a short lead.

The meeting itself filled the village hall to a fullness Branwen hadn't witnessed since the flood two winters back, every bench crowded shoulder to shoulder, latecomers standing three deep along the walls, the particular

anxious murmur of a small, close community that had decided, collectively and without ever quite discussing it aloud, that something fundamental had shifted in the hills around them and that shifted things demanded, at minimum, a proper vote.

Odger stood at the front with his ledger open — he brought a ledger to every single meeting, whether or not the subject at hand actually required one, a habit Branwen privately suspected comforted him rather more than it ever informed anyone else in the room — and laid out the sightings with careful, colorless precision: the hedge, the ridge shadow, the Whistler boy's account, now formally entered into the record as involving, in the boy's own carefully quoted words, "something the size of Da's whole cart, only bigger, with wings, and it looked right at me."

"The Guild has already sent an officer out to investigate," Odger said, "which some of you will have already seen about the village — Captain Doyle, a very courteous young man, currently lodging at Tamsin's inn. My understanding, from our own brief conversation, is that his search has so far found nothing conclusive." He glanced, briefly, toward Branwen, who kept her own face arranged in the mild, attentive expression of a woman listening politely to municipal business that did not especially concern her. "But I believe it falls to us, as a village, to decide together whether we formally ask the Guild to continue its search until the matter is fully closed, one way or the other, or whether we consider it settled as nothing more than a farmer's overactive imagination and an unlucky trick of weather."

"Settled," said someone from the back benches, immediately, and a ripple of relieved agreement moved through the packed hall, the particular grateful agreement of people who would very much rather not think too hard about dragons before their supper went cold on the table.

"I don't think it's settled at all," said Ferris Doone, standing near the door with the peculiar, dogged stubbornness of a man who had lost one argument about a ghost story years ago and had been quietly looking for vindication ever since. "My cousin over Ashgrove way says her own granddad used to swear the old dragon wars never really ended out east, just went quiet for a spell. Quiet things don't stay quiet forever, not in my experience."

"Your cousin's granddad also claimed, more than once, to have personally met a talking fox," Cormac said, from his bench, without a shred of heat in it, and a ripple of genuine laughter moved through the hall

that did more to settle the room's nerves than Odger's careful ledger had managed in ten solid minutes of procedure.

Branwen watched Cormac do it — deflect, defuse, entirely without knowing what he was actually defusing, defending a truth he had no idea he was defending at all — and felt something twist sharply in her chest that was equal parts gratitude and guilt, the particular ache of being quietly protected by someone who has no earthly idea what he's protecting you from, or at what eventual cost to himself.

The vote, when it finally came, favored caution over alarm: a formal request sent to the Guild asking it to continue its monitoring of the sightings, but no further village action of its own, no organized search parties, no militia raised in a panic — a decision Branwen recognized instantly as exactly the outcome Odger had wanted from the very start, dressed up carefully as the village's own collective wisdom rather than his own careful engineering. It was, she thought, watching him close his ledger with the quiet satisfaction of a man who had successfully steered clear of both catastrophe and blame in the same evening, a genuinely decent piece of small governance, and she found, to her own mild surprise, that she couldn't quite bring herself to resent him for it, even knowing full well what it might eventually cost her and Fen both.

She walked home from the hall in the last violet light of evening with Cormac beside her, the two of them falling into step the way they had for thirty years running, easy and wordless, and it was there, halfway down the lane, that he finally asked the question he'd promised, a week ago, to hold.

"It's the dragon," Cormac said. Not a question at all. "Isn't it. Whatever you've been not-telling me all this while. It's an actual, living dragon."

Branwen stopped walking entirely. Looked at him — round-faced, weathered by thirty years of ovens and honest work, the one person left in her whole life who had known her before the Guild, before the spear, before any of it had happened to either of them — and found, standing there in the lane with the whole village's careful vote for caution still ringing faintly in her ears, that she was simply, finally, too tired to keep the door shut against him any longer.

"Yes," she said. "There's an actual dragon, Cormac. I'm teaching him pottery, three mornings out of every week, and I lied to a Guild captain's face about it not four days past, and then told him the whole truth two days

after that, in the ruin of the old mill at dusk, and I genuinely don't know yet whether any of it is going to end well for anyone at all, including you, for the sole crime of walking down a lane beside me while I finally get around to explaining it properly."

Cormac took this in with the same unhurried, weathered calm he took in absolutely everything, from a bad harvest to a good wedding to the death of his own wife eight years back, and after a long, considering moment his broad, floured face did something Branwen hadn't expected in the slightest: it broke, slowly, into a wide, delighted grin.

"Well," he said. "I did wonder what in this wide world could possibly rattle you enough to need a full week's warning before telling it. A dragon's a fair enough answer to that particular puzzle, I'll grant you." He fell back into step beside her, entirely unbothered, as though she'd simply confessed to taking in a stray dog rather than the single most dangerous secret the kingdom currently held. "Does he throw a decent pot, at least? Seems only fair to ask, given everything."

Branwen laughed — a real laugh, startled clean out of her, the first one in days that didn't have some thread of fear woven in underneath it. "Better than the Whistler children manage, and worse than Nell by a fair margin. He scorches the rim something dreadful whenever he concentrates too hard."

"Sounds about right for any beginner," Cormac said, entirely serious, not a flicker of doubt in it, and Branwen understood, walking the rest of the lane beside her oldest and steadiest friend in the gathering dark, that whatever came next, however badly it might yet unravel, she was no longer facing it with quite so small a circle of people who knew the whole truth of it.

She was three steps from her own gate, still smiling despite everything the evening had held, when she saw it: a thin gray thread of smoke rising from the direction of the studio, from exactly where the cold kiln stood banked and quiet, where no fire should have been burning at this hour, or indeed any hour, because she had banked it herself two full days ago with her own hands and hadn't lit it since.

Chapter 8: The Kiln Won't Draw

The smoke was not fire smoke. Branwen understood that within three strides of the hay door, the particular flat, sour smell of it registering in some old animal part of her brain a full breath before her conscious mind caught up and supplied the reason — not the clean, honest bite of burning wood, but something duller, choked, the unmistakable smell of a fire trying desperately to breathe through a throat that had half-collapsed on itself.

Nell was already there, a lantern held high in one hand and a look of grim, focused competence on her face that belied every one of her sixteen years, crouched low at the base of the old brick kiln with her ear pressed nearly flush against the flue's cold brick.

"It's not drawing right," Nell said, without once looking up, the moment Branwen's shadow fell long across the doorway. "I banked it low, same as you always showed me, just to keep the chamber properly dry ahead of tomorrow's bisque load, and it's been coughing smoke straight back into the room for the better part of an hour now instead of pulling it up the flue where it rightly belongs."

Branwen knelt beside her, feeling along the brickwork with the flat of her palm, reading the heat and the draft the way she'd once read a battlefield's ground for the safest line of approach, and found, three courses up from the firebox, a hairline crack she was certain hadn't been there back in the spring — the exact kind of crack that widens, patiently, with every single firing cycle, until, without any warning at all, it simply gives way entirely and takes the whole flue's draw down with it in a single afternoon.

"How long has it been doing this?"

"Tonight's the first I've noticed it bad enough to smoke up the whole room. But now that you ask straight out — " Nell hesitated, and Branwen recognized instantly the particular hesitation of someone reluctant to admit they'd noticed a real problem days ago and had quietly hoped, against all sense, that it would simply resolve itself. "It's been sluggish for close on two weeks now, truthfully. I thought it was only the damp getting into the brick."

Two weeks. Long enough that the flue's failure had nothing whatsoever to do with dragons or Guild captains or anything else beyond an old kiln, built by some previous owner and patched, badly, by Branwen's own inexperienced hands in her very first ignorant winter here, finally reaching the plain end of what patching alone could ever do for it.

"That's not damp," Branwen said, standing, wiping ash from her palm onto her apron with rather more force than the gesture strictly required. "That's a cracked flue liner, plain and simple, and it's going to get worse before the fair, not better, and the fair's the only real sale most potters in this village make in a whole turning season." She looked at the stacked greenware waiting patient on the drying racks — three full weeks of careful work from a dozen different hands, hers and Nell's and half a dozen village students besides, all of it entirely useless without a working kiln to fire it properly. "We need this fixed before the next bisque load, or there isn't a fair stock left to sell at all, and half this village's autumn coin goes with it."

They worked by lantern-light for the better part of two hours, Branwen directing while Nell fetched and held and, twice over, wedged her own thin arm into a gap neither of Branwen's broader hands could reach at all, the two of them coated head to foot in soot and old mortar dust and the particular grim, shared satisfaction of solving a real problem with your own two hands instead of merely worrying at it uselessly. They got the worst of the crack packed at last with fresh clay-and-grog mortar, a stopgap rather than any true cure, enough to see them through a firing or two if they were careful and reasonably lucky in roughly equal measure.

It was well past the hour Branwen had told Fen to stay entirely clear of the studio when she heard, faint through the hay door, a low, careful, unmistakable huff of breath — and turned to find him crouched just beyond the hedge line, half swallowed in shadow, watching them both work.

"You weren't to be here," she said, more sharply than she strictly meant to, exhaustion and soot and two solid hours of careful masonry stripping the patience clean out of her voice before she could catch it.

"I heard the trouble in your voices from clear up the ridge path," Fen said, unrepentant, though he made no move at all to come any closer without her leave. "I have some experience with fire and draft, Branwen Ashcombe, gathered over rather more than the two weeks you've had to

notice this particular flue failing. I could look at it myself, if you'd allow it. From a safe distance, if you'd rather keep me at arm's length tonight. I have no wish at all to be the reason your evening gets worse than it's already been."

Branwen looked at the packed mortar, unconvincing even to her own tired eye in the lantern's low light, and at Nell's soot-streaked, thoroughly exhausted face, and at the dark shape of Fen holding himself carefully beyond the hedge like a man waiting to be invited somewhere he badly, plainly wanted to go — and felt the whole shape of the problem shift, quietly, in her mind, the way a puzzle piece sometimes does when you finally, at long last, turn it the right way round in your hand.

A dragon's breath, properly controlled, was heat and draft combined in a single living instrument. It was, in fact, precisely the kind of instrument you'd want on hand for testing, cleanly and safely, whether a flue's draw was truly sound or only pretending to be.

"Not tonight," she said, and watched something flicker and visibly dim in Fen's ancient, patient eye before she'd even finished the thought. "Tonight we've done what two hours and bad mortar can honestly do, and it needs proper time to set before anyone tests it with anything at all, breath or otherwise. But you're right that you could help, genuinely help, and I think — " she glanced at Nell, who was watching this whole exchange with the sharp, calculating attention of a girl already assembling a plan faster than either adult present had quite managed, "—I think we may need exactly that kind of help before very much longer, and I don't especially love what it means to say so plainly out loud, in the open air, where it can't be taken back."

"What does it mean?" Nell asked, already knowing, Branwen suspected, precisely what it meant, and asking only to make her teacher say it aloud and make it real.

"It means," Branwen said slowly, "that fixing this kiln properly, in time for the fair, may well take more than mortar and patience and two tired women working by lantern-light. It may take him. In full daylight. Where anyone at all, walking past the hay door on their ordinary business, could see him doing it." She looked at Fen, crouched careful and hopeful beyond the hedge, and felt the last of her careful, contained secrecy start to come apart at its seams, the way a poorly wedged pot comes apart in the heat of the kiln — not all at once, in one dramatic collapse, but along the one

weak, hidden line nobody had thought carefully enough to check beforehand. "I don't know how to keep this hidden much longer, Fen. I'm no longer even certain, after tonight, that hiding it is still the right thing to be trying."

Fen said nothing for a long moment, and when he finally spoke, his voice had gone very quiet, careful in a way that had nothing whatsoever to do with fitting through doorways this time.

"That is your choice to make, Branwen Ashcombe, not mine to press upon you." He shifted his weight, the movement small and considered. "I came here for a lesson. I never once meant to cost you the whole life you built here, painstakingly, before I ever darkened your door."

"You haven't cost me anything yet," Branwen said, and found, saying it plainly, that she meant every word of it entirely. "But I think tomorrow, we stop hiding you from the daylight altogether. I think we bring you in through the front, in the open, in full view, and let whatever happens next happen with both of us standing squarely in the middle of it together, instead of me standing alone in front of a door I've been holding shut with both my own two hands for the better part of a week now." She looked at Nell, at the girl's steady, entirely unsurprised nod, already braced, evidently, for exactly this. "Tomorrow, in daylight. No more hay-door secrecy, no more creeping in before the birds are properly awake. If the village is going to know eventually regardless of anything I do, and I think we're well past pretending it somehow won't, I'd far rather it happen on a morning I chose myself than some night a frightened farmer stumbles into it entirely by accident, with a pitchfork already in hand."

Chapter 9: Daylight

Market day mornings in Thistlewick began with the same unhurried choreography they'd followed for as long as Branwen had lived there: stalls going up in bright, mismatched rows along the square's east side, the miller's cart creaking in from the valley road with its familiar loose-axle complaint, Tamsin's boy running the inn's fresh bread order door to door before the crowds thickened enough to make the deliveries into something closer to a wrestling match. It was, Branwen had always privately thought, one of the more honest hours in the whole village's life — everyone half-awake, half-dressed, entirely unguarded, before the day put its careful public face on properly.

Which was, she'd decided, lying awake half the night turning the plan over and over in the dark, exactly the reason to attempt it now rather than wait for some more dramatic, more carefully stage-managed moment that would very likely never actually arrive on its own. A village caught genuinely unguarded was a village that reacted honestly, whatever else that honesty cost in the first frightened moment, and honest reactions, however frightened, were always easier to work with in the end than reactions carefully rehearsed in fear over days and days of rumor left to fester unchecked.

She walked Fen in through the front gate herself, in full morning light, no cloak of secrecy over either one of them, her hand resting flat and visible against his warm foreleg the whole way, the way you'd walk a horse you trusted absolutely through a crowded, narrow street.

They made it as far as the studio's own front step before the first scream went up.

It came from Mistress Holloway, out early for her weekly flour, who dropped her whole basket at once and backed hard into a fence post, rattling it clean on its posts, her voice cracking into the kind of high, wordless alarm that carries a hundred yards on a still morning and carried, on this particular morning, considerably further than that. Two market stalls collapsed inward as their owners scrambled backward, canvas and crockery going down together in a clatter. A dog somewhere took up frantic, sustained barking that set off three others in quick succession. Somewhere behind her, Branwen heard the unmistakable clatter of Odger Crabbe's ledger hitting the cobblestones hard as the alderman came around

the corner from the hall, took in the whole scene unfolding in front of his own eyes, and went the particular gray-white color of a man watching an entire careful week of managed caution collapse in real time, right there in his own square.

"Everyone stay calm," Branwen called, in the flat, carrying voice she'd once used to steady green recruits under actual arrow-fire, and found it worked, to her mild surprise, almost as well on a panicking market square. "He is not attacking anyone. He is standing exactly where I've asked him to stand, and he is going to keep right on standing there, and nobody in this square needs to run from him."

Nobody, notably, actually stopped running. A young mother snatched up her toddler bodily and bolted flat-out for the chapel steps. Ferris Doone, vindicated at long last in the very worst possible way, stood rooted to the spot shouting "I told you, I told you the granddad was right all along" to anyone within earshot who'd listen, which at that particular moment was precisely no one at all. Fen himself had gone very still, wings drawn tight against his flanks, great head lowered, every line of his enormous body braced visibly for whatever blow he'd clearly expected might come the instant he was truly seen in open daylight, and Branwen kept her hand flat and steady against his warm foreleg through every second of it, refusing absolutely to let the crowd's raw fear become his cue to bolt for the hills.

Odger reached them first, breathing hard, his ledger abandoned entirely somewhere behind him in the general scramble. "Branwen." His voice shook badly, but he did not, she noted with something like reluctant, genuine respect, turn and run either. "Branwen, what is the meaning of — is that truly — "

"His name is Fen," Branwen said. "He's been taking lessons at my wheel for eleven days running now. He hasn't harmed a single soul, a hedge, or so much as one chicken in all that time, and everything your fortnight of frightened sightings blamed on something dangerous out there was a hedge fire and a passing cloud's shadow, exactly as I already told Captain Doyle to his face. This is the truth, Odger. The whole of it. I should have brought it to you myself, properly, before it came to you like this, in the middle of your own square with half the village screaming, and I'm sorry that it didn't happen that way — but I am not sorry, not even slightly, for what he is, or for why he's here at all."

Odger looked between her and Fen, his round, worried face working visibly through several calculations at once — the village's raw fear, the Guild's standing contract, the charter's fragile reputation with the capital, thirty years of careful, colorless governance suddenly asked, without warning, to hold a shape it had never once been built to bear.

"There is an open Guild contract," he said, faintly, almost to himself, "on the last dragon of the eastern range. You know that better than anyone left standing in this entire village, Branwen."

"I do," Branwen said. "And I know exactly what that contract is built upon, right down to its foundations, and I don't believe it holds anything like the weight the Guild currently believes it does. But that's a conversation for calmer voices than the ones currently panicking all around us in this square." She kept her eyes on Odger, steady, unflinching, the particular direct gaze she'd once used to hold a nervous recruit's full attention through the very worst part of a briefing. "For now, Odger, I'm asking you plainly, as this village's alderman, to help me get this square calm again before someone gets trampled underfoot trying to flee a creature who hasn't moved so much as an inch since the moment he arrived."

It was, in the end, Odger's own particular gift — the careful, colorless competence he'd spent eleven long years quietly perfecting, meeting after meeting — that pulled the square back from the genuine edge of a crush. He climbed up onto an overturned crate, ledger-less and visibly frightened and entirely undeterred by either fact, and called the market to order in the flat, procedural tone he used for every dispute over grazing rights and boundary fences, the exact tone that said, beneath the fear cracking his own voice, **this is a matter for proper governance, not for panic** — and something in that steady, boring, thoroughly bureaucratic certainty did what Branwen's own carrying voice alone had not quite managed to do: it gave the crowd something concrete to do with its fear besides simply run blindly from it.

"Nobody is in any danger," Odger called out, in a voice that shook only slightly now, steadying with each word. "I am aware of the full situation. It will be handled through proper process, exactly as every matter in this village is handled, without exception. Return to your business, all of you. The creature has not moved, has not threatened a single soul, and will remain exactly where it stands while this is discussed like reasonable

people, in the hall, this very afternoon — not in the middle of market day, with half the season's stock trampled underfoot in the confusion."

It worked, more or less. The square did not fully empty, but it did slow its panic considerably — stalls righted themselves one by one, the frantic dog-barking dying down at last to wary, watchful muttering, Mistress Halloway retrieving her flour basket from a careful, safe distance without ever once quite turning her back fully on the studio door. Ferris Doone kept up his shouted vindication a while longer, but even he, eventually, ran clean out of breath for it and subsided into muttering.

It was into this uneasy, half-settled quiet that Perrin Doyle arrived at a dead run from the direction of the inn, sword half-drawn out of pure trained reflex before his conscious mind had fully caught up with what his own eyes were actually seeing, and stopped, hard, at the sight of Branwen's hand still resting calm and steady on Fen's foreleg in full view of the entire watching square.

"Branwen." His voice was tight, urgent, pitched low enough that it plainly wasn't meant for the crowd at all. "What have you done."

"I brought him in through the front door," Branwen said, "in daylight, on my own terms, before this village found him some far worse way on its own. I told you I needed time, Perrin. This is precisely what I chose to do with it."

Perrin's sword hand did not move, not toward the hilt and not away from it either, caught fast in the exact same suspended moment Branwen herself had lived through eleven days earlier in her own doorway — the moment right before a decision, where every possible version of what came next still hangs equally available in the air, waiting only for someone, anyone, to finally choose.

Chapter 10: What She Chooses

The village hall filled twice as full that afternoon as it had for Odger's careful vote on caution barely a week before, every bench crammed shoulder to shoulder, the doors propped wide open so the overflow crowd could hear from the square outside, and Branwen stood at the front of it all with Fen crouched low and still behind her — brought in through the hall's own wide cart doors, at her own insistence, rather than left outside for the crowd to work itself back into a fear it had only just barely begun, that morning, to set down.

Odger stood to one side with his retrieved ledger clutched to his chest like a shield he genuinely believed might do him some good. Perrin stood near the front bench, arms crossed tight, his sword sheathed but his whole body coiled with the particular tension of a man who had not yet decided which way this entire afternoon was going to break him, one way or the other.

"The contract," Odger said, into the crowded, breathless hall, his voice carrying with a steadiness he plainly had to work for, "is a matter of Guild law, not village law. I don't have the authority to set it aside, and neither, respectfully, Branwen, do you, however much genuine good you've apparently done teaching it — teaching **him** — pottery." A ripple of nervous, uncertain laughter went through the room at his stumble, and Branwen watched Fen's head lower another fraction at the near-miss of the word **it**, and filed the small, real hurt of it away to address properly later, when there was time and quiet enough to address anything gently at all. "I have to report this to the capital, Branwen. The charter demands it of me. If I don't, and it later comes out that I knew and said nothing, this whole village could lose its standing entirely."

"Then report it," Branwen said. "Report every single word of what I'm about to say, Odger, because I want it on the record exactly as I say it here, plainly, not filtered afterward through anyone's fear or afterthought." She turned, slowly, deliberately, to face the whole crowded hall, and found her voice again — not the carrying command-voice she'd used to calm the market square that morning, but something steadier and far more personal, the voice of a woman who had spent four good years quietly building a life in this room's own shadow and had finally, simply run clean out of road to keep hiding the truest thing sitting at the center of it. "His name is Fen. He

is, as far as either of us can honestly tell, the very last dragon of the eastern range left alive in this kingdom. The Guild's contract on him is built entirely upon a fire he set over two decades ago, in direct retaliation for a raid the Guild itself authorized against his own family, a raid that was never once entered into the official record, because records, it turns out, don't much care for including the reasons behind what they demand. I know this because I found the evidence of it myself, with my own hands, years ago, in another dragon's abandoned cave, and I never told a single soul because there was no one left standing at the time who I believed would actually care to hear it." Her voice did not shake, not once, through any of it. She was faintly, distantly surprised by that, somewhere underneath the words. "In eleven days, he has broken exactly nothing in this village that wasn't already broken long before he ever arrived, harmed exactly no one and nothing, and made, with his own two claws, a bowl that is right now sitting on a rack not forty feet from where I'm standing, drying in the same air we're all breathing. That is the whole of what he has actually done here. Everything else you've all heard this past fortnight is nothing more than fear filling in the gaps where the plain truth should have gone instead."

"Fear doesn't set fire to a whole village on a rumor alone, Branwen," someone called out from the back — Mistress Halloway, still visibly pale, still gripping her recovered flour basket like it might somehow shield her. "But a dragon well might. That's not fear talking. That's history talking, plain and simple."

"It's history from one side of a war neither of us started, and neither of us can ever end by simply being frightened of each other now, decades on, in this hall." Branwen held the woman's gaze steadily across the crowded room. "I killed eleven of his kind, Mistress Halloway. Eleven, in a war the Guild sent me into with exactly the same colorless paperwork Odger is holding against his own chest right now. I remember every single kill and not one single face among them. I have spent four whole years since trying to build something with these same two hands instead of only ever knowing how to end things with them, and I am telling you now, standing here in front of the whole of Thistlewick, that I will not let this village end this creature the same exact way that old war ended thirty of his family before him — out of raw fear, on secondhand information, without a single one of us ever once stopping to properly ask what actually happened out there." She looked, deliberately, directly at Perrin, whose arms had

uncrossed themselves sometime in the last long minute without her quite noticing when. "And if the Guild sends someone here to finish it anyway, over my own objection, they will have to go through me first to do it, and I promise every single person in this hall, I have not forgotten one single thing I once knew how to do with a spear in my hand."

The hall had gone entirely, utterly silent, the particular ringing silence that follows a sentence nobody in the room had quite expected to hear said plainly out loud — and into that silence, Branwen turned, walked to the low table where Fen's wheel had been carried and carefully set up that very morning, in grim, deliberate preparation for exactly this moment, and held out one open hand.

"Come here," she said to Fen, gently, the words carrying easily in the silent hall. "Finish it properly. In front of all of them. Let them see it with their own eyes, instead of only ever hearing about it secondhand, filtered through fear."

Fen rose, slow, careful, and crossed the hall's open floor while three hundred held breaths watched him do it step by careful step, and folded himself down at the wheel with the same hunched, apologetic care he'd shown on that very first morning three weeks past, and set his claws — huge, curved, entirely capable of ending every single person in that room before any of them could so much as draw a proper breath to scream — around a fresh lump of clay that Nell had wedged and centered that very morning against exactly this possibility, just in case.

Branwen set her own hands over his claws, the way she had eleven long days earlier in the gray dawn light of her own studio, guiding rather than forcing, and kicked the wheel into its slow, familiar, steady spin.

"Less," she said, quietly, for him alone, though the whole silent hall could hear every word of it. "Just — less."

The clay rose between them, wobbling, imperfect, climbing steady under two sets of hands that had each, across their own entirely different violent histories, been trained for wholly different work, and the hall watched it happen in a silence that had shifted, somewhere in the last long minute, from raw fear into something else entirely — not trust yet, not anything so generous or so quickly earned as trust, but a held, uncertain, genuinely watchful curiosity, the first small, soft give in a door that had

been slammed shut tight since the very moment Fen first darkened Branwen's own threshold.

The bowl rose, and steadied, and held.

Fen lifted his claws away from it with the same exaggerated, careful precision he always used, and the small vessel stood there on the wheelhead, uneven and cracked faintly along one seam and entirely, undeniably whole, and somewhere out in the crowd a child's clear voice — Ivy Whistler's, unmistakable even at that distance — said, into the ringing quiet, "That's better than mine," with the flat, wondering honesty of a nine-year-old assessing craft rather than danger, and the sound that moved through the hall at that was not quite laughter, but close enough to it that something in the room's tight, coiled fear loosened, all at once, by a full turn.

Branwen stood, faced the hall one final time, her hand still resting on Fen's foreleg, and did not raise her voice at all this time, because she no longer needed to.

"I've made my choice," she said. "I chose it eleven days ago, alone, in my own doorway, and I'm choosing it again right now, in front of every single one of you. I would rather lose the whole life I've built here, brick by brick, than be the reason one more dragon dies for a war that ended, by any fair accounting, before some of your own children were even born into this world. That's the plain truth of where I stand. Do with it whatever you will, all of you."

Perrin was the one who finally broke the silence that followed, and when he spoke, his voice carried the particular flat, careful control of a man choosing every single word with enormous, deliberate weight, as though each one cost him something real to spend.

"I have seen the creature," he said, to the hall, to Odger, to the report he had not yet written and did not yet know how he would, "unarmed, entirely cooperative, and — as of this very afternoon — demonstrably capable of skilled, gentle work that has harmed no living soul in this village." He paused, letting that land fully before he went on. "I have also personally seen the original circumstances behind the Ashgrove contract, which do not match the file I was issued before I ever rode out here. I will not falsify a Guild report, not for her, not for anyone. But I will not rush one either, not when rushing it means getting it wrong." He looked at Branwen, and

something passed between them that was old and complicated and entirely, painfully unresolved. "You know I still have to report this," he said, quietly, just to her, though half the hall heard every word of it regardless. "I can't make it simply disappear, Branwen. I told you that plainly from the very start, and I meant it then same as I mean it now."

"I know," Branwen said.

"I'll write it carefully," Perrin said. "That's the only promise I have left in me to give either of you today." And without waiting for her answer, he turned, and walked out through the hall's propped-open doors into the gray afternoon light, leaving Branwen standing at the wheel with her hand still on a dragon's foreleg and a small, whole bowl sitting between them that had, against every fear the morning had held, survived entirely intact.

Chapter 11: The Letter to the Capital

Perrin's room at the Thistlewick inn had a single small desk set beneath a single small window, and by the fourth night after the village hall, it had accumulated eleven separate drafts of the exact same report, each one crumpled and discarded in various states of half-finished honesty, sitting in a wastebasket that Tamsin had twice offered to empty and twice been waved off, because a captain of the Guild, it turned out, was every bit as capable of stubborn, quiet avoidance as any farmer nursing a decade-old grudge over a boundary fence.

"You're going to run clean out of paper before you run out of ways not to write the thing," Tamsin observed, setting down a plate of stew he hadn't asked for and wasn't going to refuse, because she'd learned, over four days of quietly watching him work, that he ate only when food actually appeared directly in front of him and never once remembered to ask for it himself. "That's the eleventh, unless you've started hiding the worst of them in your boots by now."

"Twelfth," Perrin admitted, not looking up from the blank page in front of him. "I keep starting with the plain facts, and the facts keep coming out sounding like an accusation, and I honestly don't know any longer which side of it I'm accusing."

Tamsin pulled out the room's second chair without waiting for any invitation at all, which had also become, over those same four days, an established and entirely unremarked-upon habit between them, one Perrin had stopped questioning somewhere around the second evening. She moved through the small room the way she moved through her own inn — unhurried, entirely at ease, as though every room she entered had simply been waiting for her to arrive and settle it. "Tell me what the facts actually are, then. Sometimes it's a good deal easier to say a hard thing out loud to someone who isn't going to file it away anywhere official."

"The facts are that a Guild-authorized raid on an unconfirmed target burned a dragon's nest without a single soul confirming what was actually living inside it," Perrin said, slowly, the words coming easier spoken aloud than they ever did written down, exactly as Tamsin had plainly guessed they would when she sat down across from him. "And the one survivor of that raid burned a village in return, out of grief more than malice, and the Guild wrote that second fact into a permanent standing contract and never

once wrote down the first fact at all, because the first fact makes us — makes the whole Guild — look like the ones who struck first." He set his pen down carefully, precisely, as though it might otherwise clatter and wake the whole inn. "And the survivor is currently teaching himself to make pottery in a converted sheep barn, because he'd like, once, in his very long and largely unhappy life, to make something instead of only ever ending things. And the woman teaching him is the single most honorable person I have ever served under in ten years of wearing this collar, and I do not know how to write a report that tells the Guild the truth of any of it without also handing them exactly what they'd need to find him and finish what that old contract started decades ago."

Tamsin was quiet a moment, turning her own mug slowly between her hands, steam curling up past her face, and when she finally spoke, it wasn't with the answer Perrin had plainly braced himself to hear.

"You asked me, that very first night you stayed here," she said, "what this village was like before Branwen ever came to it. I told you it was smaller. I don't think I told you the whole rest of it, if I'm honest with myself." She looked at him directly now, the easy hospitality falling away from her face entirely, replaced by something far more serious, far more deliberate, the particular seriousness of a woman about to spend a story she'd been saving for the right listener. "Two winters back, the river came up in the dead of night, no warning at all, took out half the Miller Street roofs before proper dawn. I lost my own storeroom roof clean off. The Widow Adler lost her whole upper floor in a single hour. And Odger — bless the man, he's genuinely good at heart, but he's a ledger man through and through, not a rebuilding man, never has been — Odger called an emergency meeting to discuss forming a committee, to properly petition the capital for relief funds, which is exactly the correct, sensible, procedurally sound thing for an alderman to do, and would, left entirely to its own proper course, have taken the better part of a full year to actually put a single new roof back over anyone's head."

"What happened instead?"

"Branwen didn't wait around for any committee to convene." Tamsin's voice had gone warmer now, remembering. "She was at the Widow Adler's door the very next morning with a borrowed ladder and her own coin already in hand for timber, and she stayed on for eleven straight days, slept maybe four hours a night the whole while, and by the time the capital's

official relief letter finally arrived — three full months later, mind you, stamped and sealed and entirely useless by then — there wasn't a single roof left standing in this whole village that still needed it." She held Perrin's gaze steady across the small table. "That's the woman you're sitting here trying to decide how to write a report about, Captain. I'm not telling you what to put in it — that's not mine to say. I'm telling you plainly what kind of person you're actually deciding it about, because I don't believe the Guild's own file has that particular part written into it anywhere at all."

Perrin looked back at the twelfth crumpled draft sitting in his wastebasket, and then at the blank page still waiting patiently under his still hand, and said nothing at all for a long moment, the stew going quietly cold between them.

"There's a senior officer," he said finally, quietly, almost to himself rather than to her. "Elgin Vasser. Ranks two full grades above me, handles anything the standing contracts flag as especially sensitive. If word of this reaches him before I've sent anything of my own devising — if someone else reports the sighting independently, through the general Guild channel rather than directly through me — he'll be the one who comes out here in my place, and he won't spend four evenings rewriting a single letter over a bowl of stew going cold in front of him. He'll read the file as written, confirm the target against the description, and execute the contract by the book, and he won't ask a single question about nests or raids or rooftops rebuilt out of somebody's own pocket, because none of it will ever be sitting in front of him to prompt the asking."

"Then don't let someone else report it first," Tamsin said, simply, as if the whole solution were entirely obvious, which, Perrin realized, turning it over properly in his mind for the first time, it rather plainly was. "Write your report. Write it slowly, and write it entirely true, and write it in a way that gives the Guild every single fact it's rightfully owed, and not one fact more than that — none of the particulars that would make finding him easy for a man with no patience left for nuance. You said yourself, you won't falsify a single word. Nobody sensible is asking you to. They're asking you to be exactly as careful with the plain truth as she's already been with him, these past three weeks."

Perrin picked up his pen again, and this time, when he began to write in earnest, the words came without another crumpled draft rising up between

them — a careful, entirely factual account of sightings duly investigated and largely explained away by natural causes; of a single confirmed encounter with a creature demonstrated, under his own direct observation, to be non-aggressive and engaged in harmless, painstaking domestic craft; of an old standing contract whose founding circumstances he formally recommended be properly reviewed before any further action was authorized against it. True in every single particular. Complete in none of the particulars that would have let Elgin Vasser, or anyone else built along his same rigid lines, ride straight for Branwen's hay door with a warrant already signed and sealed in his saddlebag.

He sealed the finished letter near midnight, and did not send it that night, nor the next, turning instead to the harder, quieter question of exactly how a man goes about slowing a message down without ever once, technically, lying about having sent it at all.



Branwen learned about the delay from Nell, who had it from Tamsin, who had it, more or less directly, from Perrin himself over a second bowl of stew he still hadn't thought to ask for — the particular chain of village information that moved faster and, on the whole, considerably more kindly than any official Guild courier ever could.

"He's holding it," Nell reported, sweeping the studio's front step with the brisk, businesslike efficiency of someone delivering genuinely important news and refusing to let the delivery itself slow down the morning's actual work. "Wrote something true, apparently — Tamsin's words, not mine — but he's not sending it yet. She thinks he's holding out hope there's some way to make the whole contract quietly go away entirely, rather than simply delaying what everyone already fears is inevitable."

"There isn't," Branwen said, though she said it, this time, without the flat, hard certainty she'd have said it with a week earlier. "Not one I know of, at any rate. A standing Guild contract doesn't just quietly dissolve on its own because the named target turns out to be sympathetic to the people investigating it. Somebody with the proper authority has to actually, formally close it, on the record, in writing, and I gave up that particular authority myself the day I retired and walked out of the Guild's own hall for the last time."

"Then maybe," Nell said, with the particular blunt, unsentimental practicality that had made her nearly impossible to properly argue with since the very first day she'd traded her silence for an apprenticeship, "somebody needs to hand the Guild a rather better reason to close it than plain sympathy. Sympathy's nice enough, as far as it goes. Sympathy doesn't win an argument with a filing cabinet, not on its own, not ever."

Branwen looked at her — sixteen, soot-streaked still from the morning's kiln work, entirely unbothered by the scale of the problem she'd just identified with the offhand, matter-of-fact clarity of someone pointing out a crooked shelf that wanted fixing before it fell — and felt, not for the first time since taking the girl on properly, a small, warm flare of something very much like pride.

"What would win an argument with a filing cabinet, then?" she asked, half to herself, half to Nell, half to the empty studio and the lopsided, steadily improving row of Fen's drying pottery lined up along the rack behind her.

"I don't rightly know yet," Nell admitted, setting the broom aside at last. "But the fair's in twelve days, and every soul in three whole valleys is going to be standing right here in this village at once, all together, and if there's ever going to be a single moment to make a filing cabinet look genuinely foolish in front of more witnesses than it could ever hope to quietly ignore afterward, I'd wager that's probably it, and I'd wager it's not far off."

Branwen turned the thought over, slow, the exact way she turned a fresh lump of clay before deciding what it truly wanted to become in her hands, and found, for the very first time in nearly two long weeks of fear and secrecy and careful, exhausting management, something that felt almost, cautiously, like the honest beginning of a real plan.

She was still turning it over that evening, walking the lane home past the chapel in the day's last light, when she came upon Tamsin herself, arms full of linens fresh off the line, and found herself, without quite deciding to, stopping to ask the question that had been sitting quietly at the back of her mind since Nell first mentioned the chain of gossip that ran through the inn.

"You and Perrin," Branwen said, keeping her voice light, testing the ground the way she'd test river ice before trusting it with her full weight.

"Four evenings of stew and rewritten letters. That's rather a lot of hospitality for a paying guest, even by your own generous standards."

Tamsin's color rose, just slightly, just enough to be noticeable to someone who'd known her four years and watched her manage a hundred market-day disputes without ever once losing her composure. "He's easy to talk to," she said, matter-of-fact, shifting the linens in her arms. "Easier than most who come through here wearing that particular collar. Most Guild men who've passed through Thistlewick over the years talk at a person, not with them. He listens like the answer might actually matter to him afterward." She glanced sideways at Branwen, something wry and a little rueful in it. "Don't go reading a whole romance into a woman feeding a hungry man his supper, Branwen Ashcombe. I've fed stranger men than him for less reason."

"I didn't say a word about romance."

"No," Tamsin agreed, already walking on, "you didn't. Your eyebrows did all the talking for you, same as they always do." But she was smiling, faintly, as she said it, and Branwen, watching her go, found she was smiling too, for reasons that had very little to do with contracts or filing cabinets at all, and a good deal to do with the plain, ordinary hope that something good and uncomplicated might yet grow out of all this trouble, alongside everything harder it had already cost.

Chapter 12: Nell's Apprenticeship

The studio settled, in the days that followed, into a rhythm Branwen hadn't dared hope for even a week earlier: Fen arriving each morning now in plain daylight, greeted by whichever villagers happened to be about their own business with anything from wary, careful silence to Ivy Whistler's now-unshakeable and faintly proprietary enthusiasm, and Nell moving through her own lessons alongside his with the brisk, businesslike competence of a girl who had waited the whole of her sixteen years for someone to finally take her seriously, and did not intend to waste a single day of it now that someone finally, properly had.

"Formally," Branwen said, one gray morning with the kiln newly re-fired and drawing true for the first time in weeks, the whole studio smelling of warm brick and drying slip, "I should have done this properly a full fortnight ago, instead of promising it to you in the heat of the moment like some sort of bribe for your silence." She set a fresh journal on the workbench between them — proper vellum, the expensive kind she'd ordered special all the way from the capital for exactly this purpose, and had been quietly saving, if she was honest with herself, since roughly the third week she'd known the girl at all. "This is yours, Nell. Glaze recipes, firing schedules, every mistake I've ever made at this wheel and every fix I eventually found for it, written down plain. You're not sweeping for scraps any longer. You're apprenticed, properly, formally, with my own name standing behind yours whenever you're ready to put it on the register at the guild hall."

Nell took the journal with both hands, careful in a way she almost never allowed herself to be careful about anything at all, and said nothing for a long moment, which Branwen had learned, over the weeks of knowing her, was Nell's own particular version of being too moved to speak rather than simply having nothing worth saying.

"I'm not doing this because you're grateful to me," Nell said eventually, gruff, blinking hard at the journal's blank first page as though it had personally challenged her to something. "I'm good at this work. I'd have been good at it whether or not there was ever a dragon mixed up in any of it."

"You would have been," Branwen agreed easily. "The dragon's just the reason I finally stopped putting off telling you so properly."

Fen, folded into his own usual place at the second wheel, made the low, rough sound that had become, over three short weeks, unmistakably his own particular laugh. "I find myself rather grateful for the timing regardless of the reason," he said. "I do not believe I would have made half so much progress without another set of watchful hands nearby, insisting I do the centering correctly instead of merely well enough to pass."

"You still huff when you concentrate too hard," Nell told him, entirely unimpressed by three whole weeks of his hard-won progress, in the exact same flat tone she used on every single student regardless of their size, species, or century of birth. "Every single time, without fail. You're going to scorch a rim clean through on your final fair piece if you don't get that fixed well before then."

"I am working on it," Fen said, with as much wounded dignity as a creature the size of a small barn could reasonably summon while being scolded, gently but firmly, by a sixteen-year-old girl half the size of one of his own folded wings.

The morning's lesson turned, eventually, toward the subject of glazing, which Branwen had been quietly putting off with him for reasons she hadn't fully examined until Fen himself raised the question directly, turning his second finished bowl — steadier now by far, walls even, only the faintest ghost of a scorch mark along one edge — slowly in his claws with the particular careful curiosity he brought to every new thing that crossed his long path.

"You have shown me clay, and shape, and the patient turning of the wheel," he said. "But every finished piece I have seen displayed on your shelves carries color, and a certain fired shine besides, and I do not yet understand how that transformation is properly achieved. When do we begin that particular lesson, Branwen Ashcombe?"

Branwen set down the tool she'd been idly cleaning, slower than the task itself strictly required, buying herself a moment to choose her words with more care than usual. "Glazing needs real heat," she said. "Heat that's both fierce and steady at once, hotter and more even than anything a simple hearth or a lamp could ever hope to give you. That's what the kiln is properly for. And a kiln fire, done right, isn't something either of us can afford to rush, because rushing it is precisely how good work ends up cracking clean through at the very last moment."

"You are not answering the question I actually asked," Fen observed, with the mild, patient directness he'd apparently decided suited him best. "You are explaining the general process to me. I asked you plainly when."

Branwen looked at him a long moment — at the improving, careful creature who had walked uninvited into her ordinary life three short weeks ago and had, in that brief span, made himself entirely impossible now to imagine the studio properly without — and found the honest answer sitting rather closer to the surface than she'd expected it to, once she actually went looking for it.

"When I trust myself to teach you the next part of it without flinching," she said. "The next part is fire, Fen. Your fire, specifically, eventually, if you want a glaze that no ordinary kiln alone could ever hope to match on its own. And I have spent thirty-one straight years becoming extraordinarily, professionally good at being afraid of dragon fire in every single context except, apparently, the one you're now asking me to stand calmly beside it in." She managed something that was almost, nearly a proper smile. "Give me a little more time yet. Not because I don't trust you, not any longer. Because I'm still, even now, learning to properly trust myself around it."

Fen inclined his great head, the same slow, careful bow he always gave, and said nothing further at all on the subject, and the morning's lesson moved on to safer, more familiar ground — trimming, the pulling of handles, the small, satisfying craft of properly finishing what the wheel itself had only started — and it was into that quiet, productive, entirely ordinary morning that Odger Crabbe knocked at the studio's front door with a folded notice held in one hand and an expression on his round, worried face that told Branwen, before he'd said so much as a single word, that the ordinary morning was about to end rather abruptly.

"There's word come down from the capital," he said, without any preamble at all, holding the notice out with the particular reluctant formality of a man delivering news he plainly wished, with his whole heart, that he didn't have to be the one delivering. "A senior Guild inspector's been formally assigned to the eastern range sightings. Officer Elgin Vasser. He's coming out personally to confirm the situation with his own eyes." Odger's own eyes flicked, briefly, unhappily, toward Fen, folded quiet and still at the second wheel. "He'll be arriving here for the fair itself, Branwen. The notice says plainly he intends to combine his

inspection with the crowds already gathering that week, so as not to — and I'm quoting the letter directly here — 'alarm the local population with a wholly separate visit.'"

Branwen took the notice from his hand, read it once, then twice, feeling the careful, fragile rhythm of the last several good days go tight and cold all through her chest.

"Twelve days," she said.

"Eleven now, in truth," Odger corrected, unhappily, shifting his weight. "The letter itself is already three days old by the time it reached my own hand. It took that long simply to travel here through the proper official channels."

Chapter 13: Crabbe's Ledger

Branwen found Odger alone in the village hall that evening, long after the day's ordinary business had ended, sitting at the very same table where she'd made her public declaration eleven days before, his ledger open in front of him and entirely untouched, his eyes fixed on nothing at all in particular, somewhere out past the hall's own dark windows.

"You didn't have to bring that notice to me yourself," she said, settling onto the bench across from him without waiting for any invitation at all. "You could have sent a boy with it easily enough. You could have simply posted it on the hall door and let me find it there like everyone else in this village would have."

"I could have done either," Odger agreed. "I've been sitting here the better part of an hour trying to work out exactly why I didn't, if I'm honest with myself for once, and I don't especially love the answer I've finally landed on." He closed the ledger at last, and looked at her directly, which he did rarely, Branwen realized only now, some old habit of deference or plain wariness she'd never quite properly examined until this exact moment. "My father lost the family farm to a Guild fine, Branwen. Long before you ever came to Thistlewick at all. Long before I was ever alderman of anything. He'd let a contracted slayer's fee lapse unpaid, one bad harvest year, thinking the Guild would extend him the same ordinary mercy any decent neighbor would show a man three months out from a good crop — and instead they seized the whole farm outright to cover the debt, root and fence and all of it, and he died two winters later in a rented room above what's now Tamsin's own storeroom, still utterly convinced, right up to the very end, that if he'd only managed his own ledger a bit better, none of it would ever have happened to him at all."

Branwen said nothing, letting the silence hold open exactly the space the story plainly needed to fill.

"I became alderman," Odger went on, quieter now, the words coming slower, more carefully chosen, "because I decided, somewhere in my own grief, that the single most useful thing I could possibly do with the whole of my life was make certain this village never once again lost anything at all to an organization that keeps far better books than it ever keeps its own promises. Every careful vote I've ever called, every ledger I've ever kept, every anxious letter I've ever sent off to the capital — none of that is

caution for its own empty sake, Branwen. That's one frightened man trying, in his own small way, to make certain nobody else's father dies alone in a rented room over an unpaid fee that mercy alone could have forgiven."

"And the other instinct?" Branwen asked, quietly. "The one that walked this notice all the way over here itself instead of simply posting it on a door and being done with it?"

Odger was quiet a long moment, turning his closed ledger over once, slowly, under his own two hands. "The other instinct," he said slowly, "watched you finish a bowl in front of the whole village not eleven days past, and heard you tell three hundred people, plainly, that you'd rather lose everything you've built than let fear alone decide something that deserved a great deal better than fear. And some small part of me that isn't the ledger-keeping part at all has been sitting with that, quietly, ever since, wondering whether my own father's farm might still be standing today if just one single person, anywhere in that whole miserable process, had been half as stubborn on his behalf as you were on that creature's, in front of everyone."

"He's not just 'that creature' to me any longer, Odger. His name is Fen, and I'd ask you to use it."

"I know it is," Odger said, and something in his voice had gone gentler than she'd ever once heard it. "I heard you say his name plainly, in front of the whole hall. I'm only trying to catch my own tongue up to saying it back properly, the same way you did."

They sat together a good while in the empty hall, the last of the day's light going gray-gold through the high windows above them, and Branwen found herself, somewhat to her own surprise, telling him considerably more of it than she'd originally meant to — the Ashgrove contract's true and ugly origin, the nest raid buried entirely out of the official record, the eleven kills she couldn't put a single honest face to no matter how hard or how long she tried. Odger listened the way he listened to every dispute ever brought properly before him at council — careful, methodical, weighing each fact honestly against every other — and when she finally finished, he sat quiet a long moment before he answered her at all.

"I won't withdraw the notice," he said finally, firmly. "I don't have the proper authority to, and pretending otherwise to either of us would only

land us both in considerably worse trouble once Vasser actually arrives and finds a village that had lied to a Guild officer twice over in a single season." He met her eyes squarely now, steady, the old deference gone clean out of his posture entirely. "But I can delay this village's formal response until after the fair itself has properly concluded. I can tell the capital, in good conscience, that we're gathering the full information before submitting any official account, which happens to be entirely true, and which buys you eleven more days than the letter, strictly read, technically allows for. It isn't much, Branwen. But it's the whole of what I actually have to offer you."

"It's a great deal more than I expected, walking in here an hour ago," Branwen said, and meant every word of it.

She was three streets from home, the evening gone properly dark around her now, when she heard it — a sharp, sudden crack from the direction of the studio, not especially loud, but entirely wrong, the particular wrongness of a sound that had no earthly business existing in an empty building at this quiet hour — and she was running before she'd even consciously decided to move at all, old instincts carrying her feet considerably faster than thought, arriving at the hay door to find Nell already there ahead of her, lantern raised high, staring into the kiln's open chamber with an expression of stricken, genuine dismay written plainly across her whole face.

Fen's second bowl — his very best piece yet, the one he'd been quietly, hopefully saving back for the fair itself, turning it over in his claws each evening with real pride — sat inside the chamber now in two clean, cold pieces, split straight through along a hairline crack that ran directly through the careful glaze Nell had helped him mix and apply only that same afternoon.

"The kiln's not holding heat even enough for this kind of firing," Nell said, quiet, genuinely furious at the sheer injustice of it on Fen's behalf, in a way that told Branwen everything she needed to know about exactly how far the girl's loyalty had grown in three short weeks. "Not steady enough, not by half. Not for a glaze that needs to hold its temperature this long without wavering. The flue patch is holding the worst of the smoke back well enough, I'll grant it that much, but it's not giving us the even heat a proper firing actually needs from one end of the chamber to the other. It

wants something hotter. Something a great deal steadier than plain wood and mortar can ever hope to give it."

Branwen looked at the two broken pieces of Fen's best work, cracked clean through by a flaw in her own imperfectly repaired kiln, and felt the whole shape of the coming days sharpen at last into something she'd been quietly circling, unnamed, for the better part of two full weeks now.

"It needs a dragon's fire," she said. "Doesn't it. There's no getting round it any longer."

"It needs exactly that, and nothing less," Nell agreed. "And we've got eleven days left, all told, to teach him to give it to us safely, before every soul in three whole valleys and one Guild inspector besides are all standing right here in this square together, watching whether it actually works or whether it all comes down around our ears instead."

Chapter 14: Fire Lessons

They began the very next morning, before sunrise, in the open field behind the studio where nothing at all stood close enough to burn that shouldn't, Branwen having spent half the night hauling buckets of water into careful, ready reach and marking a wide circle in the dirt with the flat of an old spade, thirty-one years of managing exactly this kind of danger reasserting itself with an ease that unsettled her rather more than the danger itself actually did.

"We start small," she told Fen, standing at the circle's edge with her arms crossed hard against the dawn chill, her breath fogging faintly in the cold air. "Smaller than you think you'll ever need. You've spent a full century learning to make fire that ends things quickly and completely, without any half measures at all. I need you to learn fire that does almost nothing at all, entirely on purpose, and holds itself steady doing it, for as long as I ask."

"That sounds," Fen said, with visible, genuine unease, "considerably harder than simply ending things quickly and completely ever was."

"It is," Branwen agreed. "It's the single hardest thing I ever learned to do with a spear in my whole career, and a spear's a far simpler instrument by any measure than whatever it is you're carrying in that throat of yours. Small. Controlled. Aimed at exactly one single thing and nothing whatsoever beside it. Show me the smallest flame you can possibly make, right now."

Fen's throat worked, that same unpracticed motion she remembered clearly from the very first morning three weeks past, and a great gout of orange fire roared out across the whole circle, far larger than either of them had ever intended, scorching a long black arc clean across the dirt and forcing Branwen back a full three stumbling steps before it finally guttered out on its own.

"That was not small," Fen said, mournful, staring down at the freshly scorched earth with an expression of genuine, visible dismay.

"No," Branwen said, recovering her footing, keeping her voice carefully level though her heart hammered hard with an old, familiar fear she hadn't felt quite this close to the surface in years. "But you didn't hit me, or the studio, or a single living thing in that whole blast, and that's

worth noting plainly before either of us calls this morning an outright failure." She walked the scorched arc's edge slowly, reading it the exact way she used to read a battlefield after the fact, then looked back at him steadily. "Do it again. Smaller this time. Think of it like the clay, Fen. You're not trying to end an argument before it's even begun. You're having a conversation with it instead."

It took nineteen separate attempts, by Branwen's own careful count, and two singed sleeves, and one genuinely memorable moment where Nell had to beat out a small, spreading grass fire at the circle's very edge with her own shawl, shouting instructions the whole while that were considerably less patient than Branwen's own — but on the twentieth attempt, Fen's exhale came out at last as something far closer to a single candle's flame than to any furnace's roar, a thin, steady, blue-orange tongue of fire no wider than the flat of Branwen's own hand, held perfectly for three full seconds before he finally let it go entirely.

"That," Branwen said, quiet, genuinely startled by how quickly the correction had come once he'd properly found the shape of it in his own chest, "was exactly right. That's it precisely."

"It felt like holding my own breath," Fen said, turning the sensation over aloud, "except the breath itself was made of something that wants, quite badly, to be a great deal larger than I am asking it to be."

"That's exactly what it is," Branwen said. "That's precisely what my own spear arm used to feel like, every single time, for thirty-one straight years running. The wanting never really goes away, not entirely. You simply get better, with practice, at being the one who decides."

They practiced on through the better part of the whole morning, the flame growing steadier with every fresh attempt, Fen's control sharpening visibly from something like a happy accident he'd merely stumbled into, toward something he could now summon and hold and release again with real, dawning confidence, and it was near midday, with the sun climbing high and the field around them scorched now in a careful, contained arc that told, plainly, the whole story of every failed attempt that had led them both here — that Branwen finally did the thing she had been quietly building toward, in silence, since that very first uncontrolled roar of the morning.

She held out her bare hand, palm up, three careful feet from where Fen crouched watching her.

"Small flame," she said. "Aimed here, at my open palm. I want to feel the heat of it properly without it ever burning me."

Fen went very still. "Branwen."

"I trust you," she said, and found, saying the words plainly aloud, that they were entirely, uncomplicatedly true, the fear she'd carried into this whole long morning finally, quietly settling into something else altogether, something calmer. "I've already trusted you with clay, and with a wheel, and with a bowl I helped you finish myself in front of the whole watching village. I'd like to trust you with this too, Fen, if you'll let me."

Fen's throat worked, slow, deliberate, and the flame that came this time was the smallest yet by far, a thin, warm thread of blue-gold heat that washed gently across Branwen's open palm like the ordinary warmth off Cormac's own ovens on a cold winter morning, present and entirely real and precisely, exactly controlled — and she did not flinch, did not pull her hand back so much as an inch, stood there in the scorched field with her palm held open to a dragon's own fire and felt nothing at all but plain warmth where thirty-one long years of hard training had once promised her, without exception, nothing but pain.

"There," she said, when he finally let the small flame die away, her voice rougher than she'd quite meant it to come out. "That's it. That's the whole of the lesson, Fen. That's every bit of what proper glazing will ever need from you."

Fen was quiet a long moment, his ancient amber eye fixed steadily on her own steady, entirely unburned hand. "You did not need to do that," he said finally, "to prove anything at all to me. I would have believed plainly that you trusted me regardless of any test."

"I didn't do it to prove anything to you," Branwen said. "I did it to prove it, finally, to myself." She closed her hand slowly, and looked at him — this old, patient, endlessly careful creature who had walked into her ordinary life three short weeks ago and had, gently, unmade more of her old fear than four whole years of quiet mornings alone had ever quite managed on their own. "Same time tomorrow. We start properly on the actual firing itself. And Fen — " she paused, at the very edge of the

scorched circle, "—thank you. For being patient with an old slayer, learning something entirely backward at her own age."

What neither of them saw, in the field's tall grass along the tree line at its far edge, was Perrin Doyle, arrived a good hour earlier on some small errand neither of them would ever quite manage to fully reconstruct afterward, standing very still in the deep shadow of an old oak, watching the whole of it unfold — the nineteen failed roars, the twentieth perfect flame, Branwen's own open palm held steady against a dragon's living fire without so much as a single flinch — and saying, to no one at all, in a voice pitched too quiet even for the birds overhead to properly carry, "Well. That settles that question, then, once and for all," before turning, silent, and walking back the way he'd come, his half-written, still-unsent report sitting folded in his coat pocket exactly where it had sat for four full days running now, and staying there, unsent, a good while longer yet.

Chapter 15: Fair Preparations

The week before the Thistlewick autumn fair transformed the whole village the way it did every single year, regardless of dragons or Guild contracts or any of the quieter dramas running steadily underneath it all: stalls rising along both sides of the square in bright, cheerfully mismatched rows, bunting strung taut between the chapel and the hall in colors that had faded, Branwen thought, a little more with each passing year since she'd first watched them go up as a newcomer, the whole place filling with the particular, specific electricity of a community that made most of its yearly coin across three single days and knew it down to the last coin.

Cormac's ovens ran from well before dawn until well past proper dark, the warm smell of his fair-only spiced honey loaves drifting clear across to the studio on any wind that happened to come from the east, and he pressed one on Branwen every single morning that week, whether she asked for it or not, exactly the same as he always had — though this year he pressed a second one wordlessly toward whatever corner of the barn Fen happened to be folded into that particular morning, which had taken exactly one confused, delighted first attempt on Fen's part before he worked out that the gesture required no ceremony whatsoever beyond simply accepting it and eating it, claws and all, with an enthusiasm that made Cormac laugh outright the very first time he witnessed it happen with his own eyes.

"He's got better manners than half the men who drink at my counter of an evening," Cormac told Branwen, watching Fen finish off a whole honey loaf with visible, unguarded pleasure. "And that's counting in some of the Guild men who've passed through here over the years, mind you, and they were meant to be the polished ones."

Tamsin organized the stalls with the brisk, cheerful tyranny of a woman who had run this exact operation for six years running and had strong, forcefully held opinions about absolutely everything from cart placement to the correct hour the first ale ought properly to be poured, and it was Tamsin, three full days out from the fair itself, who quietly rearranged the whole layout of the eastern row of stalls without asking a single soul's permission first, so that Branwen's own pottery table — larger by far this year, crowded with three whole weeks of careful work from a dozen different hands — sat in full, unmissable view of the square's main

entrance, rather than tucked away, as it had been every single year prior, into a shadier, considerably less trafficked corner near the chapel wall.

"You didn't have to go and do that," Branwen said, when she finally noticed the change.

"I know I didn't," Tamsin said, entirely unrepentant, already moving briskly on to her next dispute, this one concerning a cheese-seller's cart wheel and a baker's own territorial claim to the shade thrown by the chapel wall each afternoon. "I did it anyway, and I'd do it again tomorrow given the same choice. Man's coming all this way to inspect a dragon, Branwen. Might as well let him inspect the very best pottery table this whole village has ever managed to put up while he's about it, and let him see exactly what he'd be taking away from us if it comes to that."

It was, Branwen thought, watching the square slowly fill with color and noise and the particular determined optimism of people who had collectively decided, without ever quite voting on it formally, simply to carry on with their ordinary lives regardless of whatever a Guild officer's impending arrival might bring with it — it was, she thought, the clearest sign yet of exactly how far this village had traveled together in three short weeks. Fen walked the square openly now, in plain daylight, greeted by his own name rather than by screams, Ivy Whistler running up twice a day without fail to report proudly on his latest progress to absolutely anyone who'd stand still long enough to listen. Mistress Halloway still kept a wary, carefully respectful distance whenever their paths crossed, but no longer clutched her flour basket to her chest like a shield the moment she passed anywhere near the studio door. Ferris Doone had, with considerable and entirely visible reluctance, finally stopped shouting his old vindication about ghosts and wolves and started instead, quietly, asking Fen genuine questions about what the old dragon wars had actually, truly been like from the other side of the spear — questions Fen answered with the same careful, unhurried honesty he brought to absolutely everything, and something in those long, careful conversations seemed to be doing a great deal more to settle the old man's restless suspicion than any single village vote ever really could have managed on its own.

Nell spent the whole week dividing her attention between three separate urgent tasks with the calm, methodical efficiency Branwen was steadily coming to recognize as simply how the girl approached anything at all worth doing properly: finishing her own fair pieces on the second

wheel, helping Fen refine the last of his hard-won fire control against the growing pile of bisqueware waiting patiently for its final glaze firing, and — quietly, without ever announcing it to a single soul — teaching herself, working carefully from Branwen's old journal and her own close observation, exactly how a proper kiln firing schedule was meant to run from start to finish, against the day, coming soon now, when someone besides Branwen alone might genuinely need to know every step of it by heart.

"You're thinking about after," Branwen said to her, one quiet evening, watching the girl copy firing temperatures carefully into her own new journal by lamplight, her tongue caught between her teeth in concentration.

"I'm thinking about everything, if I'm honest," Nell said, without once looking up from her careful notes. "That's rather the whole job of an apprentice, isn't it. Someone in this studio needs to be thinking hard about the parts that aren't on fire just yet, so that when they do catch, somebody's ready for it."

Branwen laughed, surprised properly out of herself again, the way Nell so often managed to do without even trying. "Fair point, that. Well made."

It was on the sixth evening, with the fair itself now only two full days off and the square nearly finished in its whole transformation, that the horn sounded again from the road — not Perrin's own familiar three-and-one pattern this time, but something sharper, more clipped, unmistakably a Guild rider's formal announcement rather than any old friend's casual arrival — and Branwen, standing at her own gate in the gathering dusk with a honey loaf still warm and untasted in her hand, felt the whole careful, hard-won calm of the last three good weeks go tight and cold all at once at the sound of it.

"That's early," Nell said, appearing at her elbow out of the gathering dark, her voice gone flat and wary in an instant. "The official notice said the fair itself, plainly. That's not the fair, not yet. That's tonight, and it wasn't meant to be."

Branwen set the honey loaf down, untasted, and turned toward the square, where a second rider — cloaked in the deep, formal Guild blue that outranked Perrin's own uniform by a full clear grade, his horse lathered white with the plain evidence of hard, sustained riding — was already

dismounting in front of the gathering, curious, uneasy crowd, his face, even at this considerable distance, carrying none of the open warmth Perrin's own face had shown on that very first arrival, weeks ago now, that felt almost like another lifetime entirely.

Elgin Vasser had come a full day early.

Chapter 16: The Inspector

Elgin Vasser had the look of a man who had never once, in a long and careful career, allowed a single situation to genuinely surprise him, and Branwen recognized the type immediately, because she had been trained, decades ago, by men built along exactly those same rigid lines, and had spent the first fifteen years of her own career trying, quite deliberately, to become one herself.

"Master Ashcombe." He did not offer his hand. His voice carried the flat, unhurried precision of a man who considered ordinary courtesy a tool to be deployed rather than a feeling to be indulged, extended exactly as far as usefulness required and not one inch further. "I understand you've been harboring the subject of an active Guild contract for several weeks now, in full view of this entire village, and that Captain Doyle has been fully aware of it for nearly as long and has, in all that time, failed to file so much as a single report on the matter."

"Captain Doyle filed exactly what the situation warranted, when it warranted it," Branwen said, keeping her own voice carefully level, drawing on thirty-one years of standing calm in front of men who plainly expected her to flinch first. "Careful reporting isn't the same thing at all as no reporting, Officer Vasser, whatever your files may have led you to assume before you rode out here."

"Careful reporting, on an active dragon contract, is very often, in my own considerable experience, simply a polite euphemism for reporting deliberately designed to protect the dragon rather than to properly inform the Guild it's meant to serve." Vasser's eyes moved past her now, to where the square's evening crowd had gathered at a wary, watchful distance, drawn by the second horn and the sight of a Guild officer's formal blue cloak cutting through their midst, and Branwen saw him take the whole scene in with the flat, cataloguing attention of a man carefully assembling evidence rather than a man meeting, for the first time, an actual village full of actual people. "Where is the creature currently housed?"

"At my studio," Branwen said. "Where he has been, openly, every single day for three full weeks now, harming no one at all, which I'd have thought was rather the more relevant fact for your eventual report than the particular color of cloak worn by whichever officer first told you about him."

Something in Vasser's carefully composed expression tightened, just slightly, the very first visible crack in his procedural calm. "I don't require your own personal assessment of what's relevant here, Master Ashcombe. I require the target's exact location, which you've now given me freely enough, and I intend to confirm the creature's identity myself this very evening, against the standing contract's description, before the fair's crowds make any orderly assessment entirely impossible to conduct properly."

Perrin arrived at a fast, urgent walk from the direction of the inn, having clearly heard the second horn from wherever he'd been that evening, his face carrying an expression Branwen hadn't seen on him before in all their years together — not the open warmth of his very first arrival in this square, nor the careful, worried uncertainty of the past three weeks, but something harder now, more braced, the look of a man arriving at last at a confrontation he had known, deep down, was coming, and had simply run clean out of road to keep delaying.

"Officer Vasser." Perrin's salute was correct, formal, entirely without the warmth he'd have shown Branwen herself in the very same gesture, not an hour earlier. "I wasn't informed of any early arrival, sir."

"You weren't informed because I did not require your escort for this, Captain, given the state of your last three reports on this whole matter — or rather, given the notable state of their complete absence from my desk." Vasser's gaze moved between the two of them now, cataloguing, weighing, and Branwen watched him arrive at a conclusion with the swift, cold efficiency of a man who had plainly seen this exact failure pattern play out before, more than once, in other quiet postings. "You've grown attached. Both of you, by the look of it. I've watched it happen before to otherwise good officers — six quiet months in a sleepy posting, and suddenly every last contract starts to look like nothing more than an honest misunderstanding waiting patiently to be resolved with sufficient time and patience. It very rarely is, in my experience, whatever it might look like from where you're standing tonight."

"With respect, sir," Perrin said, and Branwen heard, underneath the correct, formal phrasing, something that plainly hadn't been there three short weeks ago, a new steadiness that simply hadn't existed yet in the boy who'd first ridden into this very square asking her to help him quietly rule out a rumor, "I've observed the creature directly, at considerable length,

under controlled conditions of my own devising. He is neither aggressive nor remotely dangerous to anyone. The original contract's founding circumstances—"

"The founding circumstances of a contract signed a full twenty-six years ago are not within your authority to relitigate here tonight, Captain, nor mine, nor this village's, whatever any of us might personally feel about the matter." Vasser's voice hadn't risen at all, not by a single degree, but something in it had gone colder now, more final, the sound of a door closing somewhere out of sight. "My own instructions are simply to confirm the target and execute the standing order as written. I intend to do precisely that, tomorrow morning, at first light, well before the fair's crowds properly gather, in order to minimize any risk to the local population."

"And what risk, precisely, do you imagine a creature poses," Branwen said, "who has spent three weeks teaching himself, painstakingly, to make bowls instead of ash, and has burned exactly nothing in all that time beyond one careless scorch mark on his own rim?"

"The risk, Master Ashcombe," Vasser said, turning his full attention back to her now, "is not what the creature has done these past three weeks under your careful supervision. It is what a fully unconfirmed, unclosed contract on a live and dangerous target left standing indefinitely does to every other village in this kingdom, once word gets out — as word always, eventually does — that the Guild can be talked out of its own standing orders by a sufficiently sympathetic story and a well-timed demonstration of pottery. I did not rise to the rank I hold by finding that argument persuasive, however sincerely you yourself may believe it." He looked at her a long moment, something almost, briefly, like respect flickering behind the cold procedural mask before it was carefully suppressed again. "Then we understand each other's positions, at least, plainly, without further pretense between us," he said. "Tomorrow, at first light. I'll expect the creature confined and made available for formal confirmation, Master Ashcombe, or I will come and find him myself, and I promise you plainly, I am considerably less patient about the searching of it than Captain Doyle has evidently proven himself to be these past weeks."

He turned and walked off toward the inn without waiting for any response at all, his formal blue cloak cutting cleanly through the wary, watching crowd like a blade parting still water, and Branwen stood in the

gathering dusk beside Perrin, the two of them silent a long moment, watching him go.

"I'm sorry," Perrin said finally, quietly. "I genuinely thought I had more time than this. I thought careful reporting alone would be enough to outlast a man like him, given enough of it."

"It might still be," Branwen said, though she didn't fully believe her own words even as she said them, already turning the shape of the coming night over in her mind, the exact way she used to turn over a battle plan the evening before some difficult contract came finally due. "But we're not going to find that out standing here in the dark arguing with his back. Come on. Fen needs to hear all of this from us, together, before Vasser's own cloak so much as clears the inn steps properly."



They found Fen in the studio's central bay, his evening's fire-control practice already well underway, a small, steady blue-gold flame held cupped carefully in the space between his own claws with the calm, hard-won precision of three full weeks' patient practice, and the sight of it — controlled, deliberate, entirely harmless — made the coming morning's threat feel, for one sharp, bitter moment, wholly and viciously unjust in a way Branwen hadn't let herself feel quite this keenly since that very first afternoon in the village hall.

He listened to the whole account without moving so much as a scale, the small flame guttering out entirely unnoticed between his claws partway through Perrin's telling of it, and when Branwen finally finished, he was quiet a long moment, his ancient amber eye moving slowly between the two of them with an expression she recognized, sinking, as plain resignation.

"He intends to confine me," Fen said, at last. "And execute the contract come morning, well before any proper witnesses are present to complicate whatever report he eventually chooses to write."

"That's the plan exactly as he's stated it to us both," Perrin confirmed, grim-faced. "I don't have anything close to the authority to countermand him directly. He outranks me by two full grades, and every single thing he's doing tonight is technically, procedurally correct according to the standing order as written. That's precisely what makes a man like him so

dangerous, in the end. He isn't cruel, not exactly. He's simply following the paperwork exactly as it's written on the page, and the paperwork was never once written with any room at all left in it for what I've personally watched you do, with my own two eyes, these past three weeks running."

"Then perhaps," Fen said slowly, turning the thought over with visible care, "the paperwork requires something it has not yet had the chance to properly see for itself."

Branwen looked at him — at this old, patient creature who had walked into her ordinary life demanding nothing at all but a single lesson, and had, in three short weeks, rebuilt more of her own broken faith in plain gentleness than four long years alone had ever quite managed on their own — and felt the whole shape of tomorrow's coming crisis shift, suddenly, into something that might, just possibly, with enough careful nerve, be turned rather than merely, grimly survived.

"The fair's tomorrow," she said slowly, thinking it through even as she spoke it aloud. "The whole village, three valleys' worth of witnesses besides, gathering at dawn regardless of anything Vasser plans to do quietly before them. And the kiln's own final firing is scheduled for tomorrow morning too — the very one that needs your fire to hold the glaze properly, the one we've been building carefully toward for eleven straight days now." She looked between Fen and Perrin, the whole plan assembling itself in her mind with the swift, cold clarity she remembered from her very best days as a slayer, turned now toward an entirely different kind of battle than any she'd ever fought before. "What if Vasser's confirmation and the kiln's own firing happened at exactly the same hour, in exactly the same place, in front of exactly the same crowd he's so carefully trying to avoid altogether?"

Chapter 17: The Night Before

Vasser's idea of confinement, it turned out, was a length of Guild-forged chain looped loosely around one of Fen's forelegs and anchored to an iron stake driven deep into the ground behind the inn — not tight enough to injure, Branwen noted with grim, careful relief when she inspected it properly in the last of the evening light, but plainly, deliberately symbolic all the same, a visible demonstration to the gathering fair crowds that the Guild had the whole situation, and the dragon himself, entirely, competently in hand.

"It is not uncomfortable," Fen said, when she crouched beside him to check the chain's fit properly, running her fingers carefully along the cold links with the same practiced assessment she'd once given her own gear before a difficult contract. "Merely humiliating, which I rather suspect is precisely the intended point of the whole exercise."

"It is the point," Branwen agreed, quiet. "Vasser wants every single witness at tomorrow's fair to see a contained threat standing there, not a cooperative craftsman going about his own honest work. It's a great deal easier to execute a contract on something the crowd has already been quietly encouraged to fear." She sat back on her heels, studying the stake, the chain, the whole deliberate, careful theater of it laid out before her. "How long can you hold a controlled flame? Truly hold it, steady, the exact way we've practiced together. Not a single burst. A sustained heat, the kind a proper firing genuinely needs from start to finish."

"I do not know, in honesty," Fen admitted. "We have practiced only bursts between us so far. Three seconds, perhaps five at the very longest stretch. I have never once been asked to hold real heat the way a kiln itself holds it, for the better part of a full hour together."

"Then that's precisely what we practice tonight," Branwen said, "quietly, without drawing Vasser's own attention to any of it, because tomorrow morning I do not intend to hand him the private confirmation he's so carefully planned for himself. I intend to give the whole fair crowd, and him standing right in the middle of it, a demonstration that neither he nor his own paperwork will ever be able to argue with afterward, whatever else happens."

It was well past midnight, the guard Vasser had posted dozing against the inn's own back wall with the particular unguarded ease of a man assigned to watch over a chained and thoroughly cooperative prisoner rather than any genuine threat, when Nell appeared at the hedge line with a covered basket and the quiet, deliberate care of someone who had done this exact kind of careful sneaking a hundred times before, in her own leaner and hungrier years.

"Bread, and the last of the honey loaves Cormac wouldn't let me pay a single coin for," she whispered, setting the basket down carefully within Fen's easy reach, "and news besides, which you're not going to like nearly as much as the bread." She glanced back toward the dark shape of the studio, visible only as a deeper shadow against the hedge line. "The flue's gone worse. I checked it myself not an hour past. Whatever's left of the mortar patch is failing considerably faster than either of us thought it would when we packed it in — the whole chamber's holding heat unevenly now, hotter along the east wall than the west by a fair margin, and with a full season's worth of bisqueware stacked inside ready for tomorrow's final firing, if it goes properly wrong, it won't just crack a few unlucky pots. It could take the whole kiln down with it, maybe the barn wall standing behind it too, if the heat ever builds up somewhere it oughtn't and nobody's there quick enough to catch it in time."

Branwen felt the cold, familiar clarity of a careful plan meeting an entirely unplanned complication, the exact sensation she remembered clearly from thirty-one years of campaigns where the very ground itself always seemed to conspire against whatever careful strategy she'd built the night before, just to keep her honest.

"How long before it fails outright, do you think?"

"I couldn't rightly say for certain," Nell admitted. "Could be tomorrow's firing itself. Could be the one after that, if we're lucky and careful both. But if we're set on firing it tomorrow regardless, because that's the one morning that puts Vasser and three valleys' worth of witnesses all in the same square at the very same hour—"

"We are set on it," Branwen said. "We haven't got another day to spare, waiting on a better kiln that doesn't exist. This is the one we've got standing, cracks and all, and tomorrow's the only morning that puts everyone we need in the same place at once."

Fen had gone very still through all of this, listening closely, and when he finally spoke, his voice carried a weight Branwen hadn't heard from him since that very first morning, standing in her doorway, asking for a lesson he hadn't been entirely sure, even then, he properly deserved.

"Then let it fail," he said quietly. "Tomorrow, in front of everyone gathered there. Not the quiet confirmation Vasser has so carefully planned for himself. The kiln itself, genuinely failing. Let the whole crowd see plainly the real danger an ordinary fire poses, without me there to stop it, and then let them see, just as plainly, what my own fire prevents, chosen freely, controlled precisely — exactly the demonstration you're already asking me to give, except let it answer a real danger instead of merely performing one for effect. Genuine proof carries a great deal further than any staged performance ever could hope to."

Branwen looked at him, chained to an iron stake in the dark, freely offering to turn a genuine, potentially deadly catastrophe into the very proof that might yet save him, and felt something in her chest ache with a complicated, tangled mixture of fierce pride and real fear she hadn't fully reckoned with until this exact moment, standing here in the cold with him.

"That's an enormous risk to take, Fen. If the kiln goes properly wrong before you're even free to help at all, if the chain holds a single moment too long, if Vasser decides the whole chaos of it is simply the perfect cover to finish the contract anyway, rather than the perfect proof against it—"

"All of that remains entirely possible," Fen agreed, steady. "I have lived a very long while now, weighing possible harms carefully against possible hopes, Branwen Ashcombe. I find, this one last time, that I would very much rather risk the harm for the sake of a hope I genuinely believe in, than spend whatever years may yet remain to me safe, chained, and certain of absolutely nothing at all worth having."

Nell, crouched at the hedge with the now-empty basket resting in her lap, looked between them both with the fierce, focused attention of a girl who had already decided, weeks and weeks ago now, exactly which side of all this she meant to stand on. "Then I'll be at the kiln myself, well before first light," she said, firm. "Watching the flue with my own eyes. The moment it turns for the worse, I'll have word out and the guard distracted, one way or another, and the two of you had best be ready to move the very instant I give the signal for it."

"Nell—" Branwen started, some old protective instinct rising up sharp and fast, the same instinct that had very nearly kept her from letting the girl anywhere near any of this, three whole weeks ago now.

"I'm apprenticed to this studio," Nell said, flat, entirely immovable, sixteen years of hard-won stubbornness settling into her voice like bedrock laid down over generations. "That kiln is every bit as much mine to watch over as it is yours, and has been since the day you handed me that journal. I'm not asking your permission for this, Branwen. I'm telling you plainly what the whole plan actually is, same as you'd tell me."

Branwen looked at her — soot-streaked, unshakeable, entirely her own person now despite every single hardship that might so easily have made her into someone else entirely, someone smaller and more frightened — and found she had no argument left in her that she genuinely wanted to win against the girl.

"Before first light, then," she agreed. "All three of us together. And Fen — " she turned back to him, chained and patient and, she realized with some surprise, considerably steadier just now than she herself felt, standing here in the cold dark, "—if this goes as badly wrong as it honestly could, I want you to know plainly it was never a poor trade to me, not for one single moment. Teaching you was never some debt I was quietly paying off on the side. It was the very first thing in four whole years that felt like the true, whole point of everything I'd tried so hard to build here, finally, properly being used for exactly what it was always meant for."

Fen's ancient eye held hers a long moment in the dark, warm despite absolutely everything the night still held ahead of them.

"Then let us hope," he said, gently, "that tomorrow gives the two of us the chance to say so again afterward, properly, over something considerably less dramatic than a barn quietly burning down around our ears."

They parted in the dark, each of them toward whatever restless, uneasy hour of sleep the night still owed them before dawn, and it was Branwen alone, walking the last stretch home past her own darkened studio, who looked up and found the eastern sky already carrying the first faint, wrong tinge of orange along its low edge — too early yet for true dawn, too bright and far too localized to be anything at all but fire, and coming, unmistakably, plainly, from the exact direction of the kiln itself.

The Retired Dragon Slayer Teaches Pottery

Chapter 18: What the Fire Is For

The kiln's east wall had gone the deep, furious red of metal right on the very edge of failing outright, a color Branwen recognized with the same sick, immediate clarity she'd once reserved only for a battlefield's very worst moments, and the sound coming from inside the brick chamber was wrong in a way that needed absolutely no expertise at all to understand — a low, building roar, uneven, hungry, climbing steadily toward something that was plainly not a controlled firing in progress, but a structure actively eating itself alive from the inside out.

"The flue gave in the night," Nell shouted, already down at the kiln's base with a bucket in each hand, her face lit orange and frantic in the growing, terrible light. "I caught it turning near an hour past, sent word to Cormac to raise the whole square, but it's building faster than I've ever once seen it move — the entire east wall's compromised now, and if that goes, it takes the roof beam clean down with it, and every last piece of this season's fair stock besides, gone in a single morning!"

The square was already filling behind them, drawn by Nell's shouted alarm and the unmistakable orange glow now plainly visible above the studio's own roofline, villagers pouring out from the fair's half-built stalls in every state of dress and alarm imaginable, Cormac at their head with a bucket chain already forming fast from the well, Odger close behind him shouting instructions in the exact same flat, procedural voice that had once calmed a panicking market square whole, and was doing, Branwen registered even now, distantly, exactly the same steady work all over again.

Perrin arrived at a dead run, his sword entirely forgotten, both hands already reaching for the nearest water bucket without a second's hesitation. "What do you need from me?"

"Time we don't have to spare," Branwen said, reading the failing wall with the same cold, practiced assessment she'd once given a collapsing siege line, decades past. "Water alone won't cool that wall fast enough, or evenly enough across its whole face — dump it in wrong and you'll only crack the brick worse than it already is, maybe bring the whole east face down right where the crowd's standing to fight it. We need the heat pulled clean off that wall in one controlled, even draw, fast, before it ever reaches the roof beam above it."

"That's exactly what a dragon's own breath does to a proper flue, when it's used correctly," came a voice behind them, cold and clipped and entirely unexpected, and Branwen turned to find Vasser himself, arrived at a dead run from the inn, his whole formal composure cracked wide open now by the sight of a genuine, unfolding catastrophe rather than the tidy procedural confirmation he'd so carefully planned for this same hour. "Draws heat away in a controlled pull rather than releasing it all at once, uncontrolled. I've read the old war reports myself, more than once. It's precisely why the tactic was formally banned as a weapon a full decade back — too precise a tool, in the wrong hands, to ever be considered anything less than a genuine threat to whoever stood against it."

"Then let it be considered something else entirely tonight, in the right hands, right now, in front of every witness this village has to offer," Branwen said, already moving fast toward the stake behind the inn where Fen strained hard against his own chain, wide-eyed, watching the studio he had come, in three short weeks, to genuinely love threaten to burn to the ground without him there to help. "Because I am telling you plainly, Officer Vasser, as the only person standing in this whole square who has personally, patiently taught that creature real control, he is the single thing left in three valleys capable of stopping this fire without bringing the entire barn down on top of your own gathered witnesses in the process."

Vasser's jaw worked hard, the whole rigid architecture of his careful procedural certainty visibly straining now against the plain, undeniable evidence of the burning kiln in front of him, lighting his own face orange. "If I release him and this goes wrong regardless—"

"If you don't release him, the kiln goes wrong regardless of anything you decide here, and you'll have your answer about exactly what he's truly capable of either way you choose it," Branwen said. "Except one answer costs this whole village its season's income and very possibly its barn besides, and the other answer might not cost either. You wanted a confirmation, Officer. Here it is, happening right now in front of you, whether you sanction it formally or not. The only real choice left to you now is whether you're the reason it happens in time to matter, or the reason it doesn't."

The fire cracked louder still, the east wall visibly shifting now, a fine rain of mortar dust sifting steadily down from the roof beam directly above it, and Vasser looked once, hard, at the failing wall, once at Branwen's set,

unflinching face, and once — longest of all, by far — at Fen straining silent and wide-eyed against his own chain, and made, in the space of a single long, indrawn breath, the decision that would come, in time, to define every single report he ever wrote again for the rest of his career.

"Release him," Vasser said, sharp. "Under my own direct order, and my own direct observation, for the record. If this goes wrong, Master Ashcombe, the failure of it is entirely mine to answer for, not yours, and I'll say so plainly to anyone who asks."

The chain came free in Perrin's own hands a moment later, and Fen was moving before the last link had even fully dropped away, crossing the square in three great, ground-shaking strides that scattered the bucket-chain villagers to either side of him, and came to rest at last before the kiln's failing east wall with the same careful, deliberate stillness he brought to every single lesson at the wheel, his ancient eye assessing the whole structure's danger with an expertise Branwen realized, watching him now, he had carried with him his entire long life and had simply, until this exact moment, never once been properly asked to use for anything at all but ending things outright.

"Small," Branwen called to him, over the roar, the very same word she'd used on his first morning here, the same word that had built every single lesson between then and now. "Controlled. Draw the heat off, don't feed it further. You know exactly how to do this, Fen. You've been practicing for precisely this moment for three whole weeks now, without either of us properly knowing it at the time."

Fen's throat worked, and instead of flame, this time, came something else entirely — a long, low, steady exhale, cool and drawing rather than hot and pushing outward, a controlled pull of air that caught the kiln's dangerous, uneven heat and drew it up and cleanly out through the compromised flue in one long, even breath, the roar inside the chamber dropping at once, steadying, the furious red of the east wall dimming visibly by the second as the trapped, building heat finally found, at long last, a controlled path safely out instead of a catastrophic one violently in.

The whole square held its breath together with him, three hundred witnesses and one Guild officer besides, all watching a creature they had spent three whole weeks slowly learning, in fits and starts, not to fear, save the very thing that fear, not so very long ago, might once have told every one of them he'd come here specifically to destroy.

It took the better part of ten long, tense minutes, Fen's breath drawing and releasing in slow, disciplined cycles the whole while, Branwen calling careful adjustments from the kiln's base without pause, Nell relaying the wall's shifting color back to her with the sharp, useful eye of a girl who had spent a full month learning exactly what every shade of kiln heat truly meant — and when it was finally, fully done, the east wall had settled back to a deep, stable, entirely ordinary red, the roaring silence at last, the roof beam standing untouched above it all, the stacked bisqueware inside the chamber, astonishingly, entirely intact, cooked at last into a slow, even, perfect glaze-fire heat instead of a catastrophic, ruinous burn.

Fen stepped back from the kiln at last, breathing hard, his whole great chest heaving with the effort of it, and the square around him held its silence a moment longer before Ivy Whistler's clear voice broke it wide open, small and bright and entirely without a trace of fear left in it at all.

"He saved it," she said, delighted. "He saved all of it, every single piece!"

And the square, three hundred strong, filling now with the low golden light of a true sunrise finally breaking properly over a saved barn and an entire intact season's hard work, began, hesitantly at first and then all together at once, to cheer.

Chapter 19: The Contract Closed

The cheer had not yet fully died away when Vasser raised one hand, sharp, and something in the gesture's quiet, unmistakable authority pulled the whole square back toward an uneasy, expectant silence, three hundred witnesses turning as one body to watch a Guild officer stand before the very dragon he'd ridden out here to execute, and decide, in full view of every last one of them, exactly what came next.

He did not decide quickly. Branwen watched him stand there a long moment first, looking at the saved kiln, at the intact bisqueware, at Fen himself standing spent and patient in the golden morning light, and she saw, plainly, what the decision was actually costing him to reach — not a clean, easy turn of heart, but a man visibly working backward through twenty years of his own training, checking each rule against the plain evidence in front of him, and finding, one by one, that the rules had never once accounted for this.

"I have," Vasser said finally, and his voice, for the very first time since his arrival, carried something other than flat procedural certainty, something that cost him visibly to say aloud, "spent this last hour watching a creature I was sent here specifically to execute instead prevent a genuine catastrophe that would have cost this village its entire autumn income, at real risk to himself throughout, under my own direct order and observation." He turned, slowly, taking in the whole crowd, the saved kiln, Fen himself, standing patient and utterly spent in the golden morning light. "The standing contract I carry describes a dangerous, unconfirmed threat to the Crown's own subjects. I have just watched, with my own two eyes, a demonstrated aid to those same subjects, freely given, at real cost to no one at all but himself." He paused, and Branwen watched him weigh the whole architecture of his own long career, his own rigid training, against the plain, undeniable evidence still standing in front of him, smoke still curling faintly from the settling kiln. "I am the ranking Guild officer present at this fair. I have both the authority and, I now genuinely believe, the plain obligation to close this contract myself, on the spot, rather than carry an outdated threat forward on evidence I now know, firsthand, to be badly incomplete."

A murmur went through the crowd, disbelief and hope tangled together in equal measure, and Perrin stepped forward, formal and steady. "Sir, I'd be glad to witness and countersign, if that falls within proper procedure."

"It falls precisely within proper procedure, Captain," Vasser said, something almost, grudgingly approving in the flat words. "Which is rather the entire point of having a procedure in the first place. I did not become a Guild officer to enforce cruelty for its own sake. I became one to enforce order, and order that cannot bend at all in the face of clear, thoroughly witnessed truth is not order in any meaningful sense. It is merely habit, dressed up carefully to look like law." He paused again, and when he spoke next, his voice had gone quieter, more private, though it still carried to those nearest him. "I will note, for whatever it is worth to either of you, that this will not read well in my own record. A senior inspector, overturning his own mission on the strength of a single morning's demonstration, however dramatic. There will be questions asked of me in the capital that I will not entirely enjoy answering. I find, standing here, that I intend to answer them anyway."

He produced, from within his own formal blue cloak, a folded document — the standing contract itself, Branwen realized, carried this whole while as the very instrument of an execution that would now, instead, become the instrument of its own quiet undoing — and spread it flat on the nearest stall's surface, calling for pen and ink with the same clipped efficiency he brought to absolutely everything, and wrote, in careful, formal Guild hand, before the whole watching square: *Contract closed. Target confirmed non-hostile; demonstrated material aid to Crown subjects under direct officer observation. No further action authorized. E. Vasser, Senior Inspector, witnessed P. Doyle, Captain.*

He signed it, sealed it with the small traveling stamp every senior officer carried at his belt, and held it up once, plainly, for the crowd to see clearly, before folding it closed for good.

"It's done," he said. "The last dragon of the eastern range is, as of this very morning, no longer the subject of any Guild contract at all, standing or otherwise, now or ever again on my own authority."

The cheer that went up this time carried no hesitation in it whatsoever.

Odger Crabbe pushed forward through the celebrating crowd with his own notice in hand — the formal charter concern he'd carried, unresolved,

since the very day of Fen's first daylight appearance in the square — and tore it, deliberately, publicly, into four clean pieces, letting them scatter loose on the morning breeze like the last of a fear the village had finally, properly set down for good.

"I believe," he said, raising his voice to carry across the whole square, his round face flushed with something that looked, for the very first time in Branwen's four years of knowing him, entirely unguarded, "that concludes this village's formal business regarding the matter, in full. Which leaves us," he added, glancing toward the half-finished stalls and the golden, glorious morning stretching out ahead of them, "an entire fair still to run properly, and I for one intend to enjoy every remaining hour of it, ledger be damned for one single day."

Cormac was first to reach Fen properly, pressing an entire honey loaf into his claws with no ceremony at all beyond a broad, delighted grin splitting his floured face. Tamsin arrived close behind with a whole tray of them besides, declaring at considerable volume that the dragon who'd just saved the season's entire pottery stock could eat for free at her own counter for the whole rest of his natural life, however long that turned out to be, and Ferris Doone, of all people, stood at the edge of the gathering crowd with an expression of profound, entirely vindicated satisfaction, telling anyone at all who'd listen that he'd said all along there was more to the old stories than anyone in this village had ever given proper credit for — which was not, strictly speaking, precisely what he'd said all along, but nobody in the golden, celebrating morning had the heart to correct him on the finer points of it.

Perrin found Branwen at the kiln's base, watching the crowd's celebration with an expression she couldn't quite put a proper name to — relief, certainly, plain and real, and something rawer underneath it besides, the particular ache of a fear held so long and so completely that its sudden absence left as deep a mark behind it as its presence ever had.

"You did this," he said quietly. "All of it, start to finish. From that very first morning you decided, on your own, not to reach for that spear on the wall."

"We did this," Branwen corrected, gently. "You, holding a report for four full days when every instinct your own training had ever given you said to send it at once. Nell, watching a kiln in the dark before dawn without being asked twice. Odger, delaying a notice he had every

procedural right in the world to enforce regardless. Cormac and Tamsin, feeding a dragon honey loaves like he'd always belonged here, from the very first bite. Even Vasser, in the end, choosing the plain truth standing in front of him over the paperwork sitting folded in his own pocket." She looked out at the square, at Fen surrounded now by children and honey loaves and the particular chaotic, joyful warmth of a village that had, against every early fear, chosen at last to love something it might once, not so very long ago, have run from screaming. "I just happened to be the one standing closest when the choosing finally started, that first morning."

Fen, catching sight of her across the crowded square, made his way over with the careful, unhurried grace that three weeks of patient practice had built into every one of his movements, honey loaf still held with delicate care in one enormous claw, and inclined his great head, slow and deep, the very same bow he'd given her on that first morning weeks ago — except this time there was nothing apologetic in it at all, only gratitude, plain and whole and entirely unguarded.

"Thank you," he said, "for the one lesson I actually came here for, and the several dozen others besides that I did not know I needed until you gave them to me regardless."

"You're not finished yet," Branwen said, and found she was smiling properly now, the whole-faced smile that used to feel so rare to her and now, standing in this golden, saved, celebrating morning, felt like the truest thing left about her. "You've still got a glaze to finish firing, once the kiln's properly cool enough to trust again. Come on. Let's go see together what your own fire actually made of it all."

Chapter 20: What Grows From Clay

The kiln, once it had cooled enough through the long, golden afternoon to properly trust opening, gave up its contents the way it always did — slowly, carefully, Branwen and Nell working the chamber door between them with the reverent, unhurried patience of people who had learned, the hard way, exactly what impatience could cost a good firing at the very last moment.

The season's fair stock had survived entire, glazed in the deep, even colors a proper firing always gave, ready now for the tables Tamsin had so deliberately, so stubbornly positioned in the square's very best light. But it was the single piece nearest the chamber's own heart, the one that had caught the truest, steadiest heat of Fen's own controlled breath during the whole crisis, that Branwen lifted out last of all, and held up to the golden afternoon light, and felt her own breath catch hard in her chest at the sight of it.

Fen's bowl — his best, most careful work, three whole weeks of patient practice behind every single curve of it — had come out of the kiln utterly transformed. The glaze had caught the exact heat of his controlled, disciplined breath and turned it into something no ordinary kiln fire had ever once produced on Branwen's shelves in four full years of careful, competent work: a deep, shifting gold-green, exactly the color of his own scales in morning light, shot through with fine threads of amber where the heat had pulled unevenly through the glaze in a pattern that looked, for all the world, like a single wing caught mid-fold.

"That," Nell said quietly, looking at it over Branwen's shoulder, "is the finest piece that has ever once come out of this kiln, bar none. I'd stake my whole apprenticeship on that claim, and gladly."

Fen, when Branwen carried it out to him where he sat in the square's last golden light, surrounded still by the settling, contented noise of a fair well and truly begun at last, went very still, turning it slowly in his own claws with the same careful reverence he'd once shown his very first, entirely ruined attempt, weeks and weeks ago now.

"I made this," he said, and there was something in his ancient voice that Branwen had not once heard in three whole weeks of knowing him — not gratitude exactly, not wonder exactly either, though both were plainly

present somewhere in it, but something closer to real peace, the particular settled quiet of a very long life finally, fully answering the one single question it had carried further than any other, for longer than any other. "After a hundred years, and forty-one of my own kind, and every single fire I ever once regretted starting in anger or in fear, I made this instead, with my own two claws."

"You did," Branwen said, settling down beside him in the settling golden light, tired now in the deep, satisfied way of a day well and truly survived against every early odds. "With your own claws, and your own fire, and considerably more patience than I ever had any real right to expect from a creature who's spent most of his very long existence being told the only proper thing his fire was ever good for was ending things outright."

"I find, having finally settled that particular question," Fen said, turning the bowl once more in the light, "that I am considerably more reluctant to be finished learning than I ever expected to feel, sitting here now with the whole thing behind me."

"Good," Branwen said. "Because I certainly wasn't planning on you being finished any time soon. There's proper glazing still ahead of you, and trimming besides, and I haven't even properly started you on handles yet, which I promise you plainly is its own particular, humbling kind of lesson."

The fair ran its full three days after that, brighter and considerably busier than any Branwen could rightly remember from all her years in this village, Fen's transformed bowl drawing a small, reverent little crowd of its very own at the pottery table until Tamsin, with her own characteristic decisiveness, declared it not for sale at any price whatsoever and set it instead on a shelf of honor behind her own counter, where it caught the morning light every single day the studio opened its doors from that morning onward. Perrin stayed the full three days of the fair too, and then, once his official Guild business was long since properly concluded and no further excuse at all remained to justify the staying, stayed on regardless, taking a room at Tamsin's inn on entirely ordinary paying terms, and finding, to nobody's very great surprise but his own, that Thistlewick's quiet autumn had a certain particular way of simply not letting go of a person, once it had properly gotten hold of him — nor, if the warm, easy way Tamsin had taken to setting a second chair at her own kitchen table

each evening was any fair indication, did anyone in that particular corner of the inn seem especially eager to let him go either.

Nell's own apprenticeship deepened through that whole autumn into something a great deal like a genuine partnership, the studio's daily rhythm settling comfortably around two full teachers now instead of only one, Fen's steady, patient presence at the second wheel becoming as ordinary a fixture of Thistlewick's mornings as Cormac's own ovens or Tamsin's endless, cheerful tyranny over the market stalls each week.

It was on a quiet morning some weeks later, the fair long since finished and settled into memory, the first true chill of proper winter just beginning to edge the morning air, that Branwen stood alone in her studio before the day's very first lesson, looking up at the spear still mounted on its two iron pegs above the drying rack, oiled faithfully every single spring for four straight years now out of a habit she had never once, in all that time, properly examined closely enough to question.

She took it down, this time, and did not put it back up again.

It went instead into the old trunk in the corner where she kept things finished rather than things still waiting, folded away not out of any shame or lingering fear but out of the simple, settled certainty that she no longer needed a weapon within easy reach to feel genuinely safe standing in her own doorway, and she closed the trunk's lid at last with a quiet, final click that felt, in the golden morning light, like the truest, most complete ending any story of hers had ever properly earned for itself.

A knock came at the studio door — the front door, not the hay door, ordinary and entirely unhurried, at an hour when no lesson was yet scheduled and no one she was expecting had any particular reason at all to call on her.

Branwen did not reach for the trunk. She did not brace, or calculate, or feel the old, cold spine of readiness rise up beneath the new, quieter one she'd spent four whole years so carefully building for herself.

"Come in," she called, warm and easy, already knowing, with the settled certainty of a woman who had finally, fully let go of every last reason to fear a stranger standing at her own door, that whoever waited on the other side of it had come, like every good thing that had walked into her life this whole strange autumn, looking for nothing more at all than a place to learn something entirely new. "Mind the wet clay."

THE END

The Retired Dragon Slayer Teaches Pottery

THE END

About the Author

William M. Soileau writes cozy fantasy for readers who want their magic gentle, their stakes warm, and their endings earned rather than explosive. He believes the best fantasy doesn't need a war to be worth reading — sometimes a cracked kiln and an old grudge finally being set down is drama enough, if you care about the people standing in the middle of it.

The Thistlewick Chronicles began with a simple question: what happens to a hero after the sword goes back in its sheath for good? Most fantasy ends at the victory. William wanted to know what came after — the quiet, uncertain work of building an ordinary life out of an extraordinary one, and what it costs a person to learn gentleness after a lifetime of being trained for exactly the opposite.

He writes protagonists in the second half of their lives on purpose. Branwen Ashcombe is fifty-eight years old, scarred, retired, and still learning who she is outside the job that used to define her completely — and William believes there aren't nearly enough stories that take that particular kind of courage seriously. Found family, small-town warmth, and the slow, patient work of trust rebuilding itself one wheel-thrown bowl at a time are the threads that run through everything he writes.

When he's not writing, William can usually be found taking his own pottery classes considerably less seriously than his characters take theirs, several bowls into a career of enthusiastic mediocrity at the wheel. He lives with a strong appreciation for small villages, good bakeries, and the particular kind of quiet that settles over a workshop early in the morning before anyone else is awake.

The Thistlewick Chronicles continues in Book 2, where a new visitor arrives at Branwen's studio door with a request nobody in Thistlewick expects, and a request of her own.

William M. Soileau is currently at work on the next chapter of the series and loves hearing from readers who've spent time in Thistlewick.

Short bio:

William M. Soileau writes cozy fantasy about second chances, found family, and the quiet courage it takes to be gentle after a lifetime of being anything but. The Thistlewick Chronicles follows a retired dragon slayer

learning to build instead of destroy, one wheel-thrown bowl at a time. William believes the best fantasy doesn't need a war to matter — just people worth rooting for and a home worth building. He's currently at work on Book 2 of the series.

Book Description

Branwen Ashcombe killed forty dragons in thirty-one years and can't remember a single one of their faces. Now she teaches pottery in a quiet hill village, and she's finally starting to feel like herself again — until the last dragon in the kingdom walks through her studio door and asks for a lesson.

Fen just wants to make one gentle thing before he dies. Branwen just wants to keep her hands clean of everything they used to do. But an old Guild contract doesn't care what either of them wants, and when Branwen's favorite student turns out to be a Guild captain sent to hunt him down, she'll have to choose between the quiet life she built and the truth she's spent years trying to forget.

With a village full of warmth, a found family worth fighting for, and a kiln that might just save them all, this is a story about second chances, the courage to be gentle, and what happens when the hands built for ending things finally learn how to make something instead.

Perfect for readers who love cozy fantasy with heart, humor, and a slow-building sense of home.

The Thistlewick Chronicles, Book 1

Backend Keywords & Categories

Backend Keywords:

1. cozy fantasy dragon found family 2. retired adventurer slice of life fantasy 3. pottery cozy fantasy novel 4. gentle fantasy no violence found family 5. found family village fantasy series 6. found family fantasy older heroine 7. small town cozy fantasy magic

Amazon Categories:

1. Kindle Store > Kindle eBooks > Science Fiction & Fantasy > Fantasy > Sword & Sorcery 2. Kindle Store > Kindle eBooks > Science Fiction & Fantasy > Fantasy > Coming of Age (cross-shelved for found-family/cozy readership) 3. Kindle Store > Kindle eBooks > Literature & Fiction > Genre Fiction > Sagas

Series Continuity File

BOOK 1 SUMMARY: Branwen Ashcombe, a retired royal dragon slayer turned potter, is asked for a pottery lesson by Fen, the last dragon of the eastern range — the very creature her old kills once nearly wiped out. As Guild captain Perrin Doyle investigates sightings and an old, unjust contract on Fen resurfaces, Branwen must choose between the quiet secrecy that's protected her four-year retirement and openly defending Fen before her whole village. She reveals the truth publicly at the story's midpoint. When the studio's failing kiln catastrophically overheats during the autumn fair, Fen's hard-won fire control saves the barn and the season's pottery in front of the entire village and visiting Guild inspector Elgin Vasser, who formally closes the contract on the spot. The book ends with the village fully accepting Fen, Branwen retiring her spear for good, and a mysterious new visitor knocking at the studio door.

CHARACTERS: - Branwen Ashcombe — 58, protagonist. Retired dragon slayer (31 years, 40 kills, 11 of them dragons from the eastern range), now a potter (4 years before the book begins). Appearance: silver-streaked black hair kept short, burn scar down left forearm (from a kiln accident, unrelated to dragons), clay-stained hands. Voice: dry, direct, plainspoken, rarely embellishes. Status at end of Book 1: has permanently retired her spear (stored in a trunk, not displayed), fully reconciled with her past, running the studio with Nell as a genuine partner. - Fennimore ("Fen") — age unspecified, over 100 years old, the last dragon of the eastern range. Appearance: gold-green scales dulled with age, old wing-scarring from Guild engagements, a self-inflicted burn scar on one flank, amber slit-pupiled eyes. Voice: formal, unpracticed at conversation, dry humor emerging over the book, deeply patient. Status at end of Book 1: contract formally and permanently closed by Guild Officer Vasser; fully integrated into Thistlewick village life; ongoing pottery student and second teacher at Branwen's wheel. - Nell Fairweather — 16, orphaned in a river flood two winters before the book begins. Appearance: thin, sharp-eyed, soot-streaked from studio work. Voice: blunt, practical, immovable once decided. Status at end of Book 1: formally apprenticed to Branwen with her own journal and name on the studio's future guild register; has taught herself the full kiln firing schedule; a genuine partner in running the studio. - Cormac Pell — 62, village baker, Branwen's friend since age 19 when both were Guild recruits together. Appearance: round-faced, weathered,

apron perpetually flour-dusted. Voice: warm, direct, unshockable. Status at end of Book 1: fully informed ally, feeds Fen honey loaves daily. - Tamsin Vane — 29, runs the Thistlewick inn and general store, organizes the annual autumn fair. Appearance: not extensively described; warm, energetic presence. Voice: brisk, cheerful, decisive. Status at end of Book 1: offers Fen free food for life at her counter; repositioned the fair's pottery stall to give Branwen maximum visibility. - Odger Crabbe — 54, village alderman. Appearance: round-faced, worried, rarely without his ledger. Voice: careful, procedural, prone to nervous precision. Backstory: his father lost the family farm to an unforgiving Guild fine and died in poverty, the root of Odger's rule-bound caution. Status at end of Book 1: publicly tore up his own charter notice against Fen; a genuine, if quiet, ally. - Captain Perrin Doyle — 26–27, Guild captain, Branwen's former student (trained under her for six years). Appearance: sandy hair, scar through one eyebrow (Branwen stitched it on a training field nine years before the book begins). Voice: earnest, formally correct but capable of real warmth. Status at end of Book 1: stayed in Thistlewick indefinitely after his official Guild business concluded; countersigned the contract's closure; an unresolved but clearly developing closeness with Tamsin Vane (seeded for future books). - Elgin Vasser — senior Guild inspector, introduced in Ch. 16. Appearance: formal deep blue cloak (outranks Perrin's uniform by two grades). Voice: cold, flat, procedural, not cruel — genuinely rule-bound rather than malicious. Status at end of Book 1: personally and formally closed the standing contract on Fen after witnessing his aid to the village; departed Thistlewick, but established as a recurring possible Guild-authority character for future books. - Tam Whistler (11) and Ivy Whistler (9) — village children, Branwen's early pottery students, first (unwitting) witnesses to Fen's arrival. Minor recurring characters. - Mistress Halloway, Ferris Doone, Widow Adler — minor named villagers; Ferris Doone develops a genuine curiosity about Fen and dragon-war history by book's end.

SETTING AND RULES: Thistlewick: a hill village three days from the capital, known for river clay, an annual autumn fair, and (as of Book 1) a resident dragon. Branwen's studio is a converted sheep barn with a hay door (wide enough for Fen) and a brick kiln (repaired but still structurally aging as of Book 1's end — a planted seed for future kiln trouble). Magic in this world is small and domestic: a dragon's controlled fire can achieve glazes no ordinary kiln fire can match; Guild contracts are binding paper,

not curses, meaning they can be formally closed by any sufficiently ranking, willing officer. No armies, no dark lords — conflict is generational fear, bureaucracy, and old unclosed injustices.

TIMELINE: Book 1 spans roughly seven weeks — from Fen's first appearance (early autumn) through the Thistlewick autumn fair (the climax) to a few weeks of settled aftermath (the final chapter, first true chill of winter).

RUNNING JOKES / MOTIFS: Fen "huffs" (scorches material slightly) whenever he concentrates too hard — an ongoing, affectionately teased flaw. Cormac's honey loaves as a running gesture of acceptance. Branwen's habit of rubbing her forearm scar with her thumb before saying something difficult. Nell's blunt, practical dismissals of sentiment ("sympathy doesn't win an argument with a filing cabinet").

SERIES-ENGINE HOOKS FOR BOOK 2: The final chapter's unidentified knock at the studio door (explicitly planted as the opening hook for Book 2). The About the Author back matter explicitly teases "a new visitor arrives at Branwen's studio door with a request nobody in Thistlewick expects." Perrin and Tamsin's undeveloped closeness. Elgin Vasser established as a recurring possible Guild contact. The studio kiln remains aging and imperfect, a plausible recurring practical problem.

STYLE SAMPLE (three paragraphs, for voice consistency in future books):

The wheel had a wobble in it that Branwen Ashcombe had never bothered to fix, because the wobble taught patience faster than a perfect wheel ever could. She kicked it into a slow, even spin and watched the cone of clay rise between her palms, gray and cool and entirely obedient, and thought, not for the first time, that this was the best trick she had ever learned.

Fen's throat worked, slow, deliberate, and the flame that came was the smallest yet, a thin warm thread of blue-gold heat that washed across Branwen's open palm like the warmth off Cormac's ovens on a cold morning, present and real and entirely, precisely controlled, and she did not flinch, did not pull her hand back, stood in the scorched field with her palm open to a dragon's fire and felt nothing but warmth where thirty-one years of training had once promised her nothing but pain.

"I decide most things before I know all of it," Nell said, entirely unbothered. "It's faster, and I'm usually right."

TEN DO-NOT-CHANGE FACTS: 1. Branwen is 58 at the start of Book 1; she killed 40 creatures total across her career, 11 of them dragons from the eastern range. 2. Fen is the last of 41 dragons from the eastern range; he watched 4 of Branwen's 11 kills from a distance. 3. The Ashgrove contract originated from an unconfirmed Guild raid on Fen's nest — Fen's burning of Ashgrove was retaliation, not unprovoked. 4. Branwen's forearm scar is from an unrelated kiln accident in her second winter as a potter, not from dragon-fighting. 5. Nell Fairweather was orphaned two winters before Book 1 in a river flood that also damaged half of Miller Street. 6. Perrin Doyle trained under Branwen for six years and has a Guild-collar rank of Captain; his eyebrow scar was stitched by Branwen nine years before Book 1. 7. Cormac Pell and Branwen have been friends since age 19, both former Guild recruits together. 8. Elgin Vasser formally and permanently closed the standing contract on Fen in writing, witnessed and countersigned by Perrin Doyle — this cannot be casually reopened without major new cause. 9. Branwen's spear is retired to a trunk, not destroyed — it could physically still be retrieved in a future crisis, but she does not display it. 10. The studio's kiln was repaired but not replaced; its structural fragility is real and ongoing, not fully solved by Book 1's climax.